can't promise tomorrow, but i can promise tonight

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by honeybakedtea

Summary

In no universe should he have to witness Mydei's hand linger on Phainon's shoulder for a moment longer than what two friends consider proper, and then watch as Mydei flexes his hand right afterwards, clearly so affected by it. Like something straight out of March's romance novels.

Seriously, Phainon's eyes had *softened* when he looked at Mydei. Multiple times. In public! And here Caelus thought eyes could only soften in Jing Yuan fanfiction.

Dan Heng gives him a look. "Phainon and Mydei are good friends. They're bound to bicker every once in a while."

Caelus sits up, wholly indignant. "Have you *seen* them," he demands.

In which Caelus meddles.

Notes

note: implied myphai but it's so vague that honestly it could be read as phaidei if u wanted. take ur pick

happy mydei day! i really wanted to make something profound for these two but instead caelus ended up fujoing out the entire time. maybe someday

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

If Caelus could give himself a title besides Galactic Baseballer, Trailblazer, and He With The Shittiest Gacha Luck, he thinks he'd call himself the Galaxy's Most Pitiful Third Wheeler To Ever Wheel.

He knew that his luck was bad in Belobog. It got worse, somehow, in the Luofu—probably because he was third wheeling three people (fourth-wheeling?), but only one of the three actually remembered the relationship. So he was thankful when he did very little third-wheeling in Penacony—probably since they had the more pressing issue of Sunday attempting to rewrite an entire reality looming over their heads.

Caelus thinks that any normal person, after wheeling as hard as he has on three different planets, would hope that the next destination would have no 'rivals to lovers' or 'doomed yaoi' or even 'eyefucking' (the latter, in particular, is something that even he with his brazenness had *no idea* how to deal with). He's begged this to the Aeons out there, and then to Pom-Pom, and then to the doleful eyes of March's plushies while she laughed at him.

So when Caelus sits through two whole hours of Mydei and Phainon bickering and giving each other heated gazes when they think the other isn't looking, he thinks, in order: *not again* and *how the fuck are these two even worse than all the others* and *did Kafka bring me into this universe to become its third wheel or something,* before immediately dragging Dan Heng away to discuss.

"So," Caelus says, sat cross-legged in the bedroom that Aglaea had gifted to them, hope brimming in his Stellaron-ridden heart.

Dan Heng glances at him, takes one look at his trusty whiteboard, and promptly turns his back.

"No."

"You haven't even heard me out!" Caelus protests.

"The answer is still no," Dan Heng says. He crosses his arms. "Your whiteboard has never yielded anything positive."

"Okay, first off, that's a lie, because you like my ideas and you know it," Caelus counters. "Secondly, this is a serious matter, and it requires both of us. I can't do it alone." He places a hand piously on his heart, Sunday-style. "I solemnly swear this on the twelve long months of life I've lived thus far."

Dan Heng ignores him, so Caelus tries a different tack. “I swear on every trashcan in Amphoreus.”

“There are no trashcans in Amphoreus,” Dan Heng finally sighs. It’s long-suffering and familiar, and Caelus loves it so. “Fine. What are you proposing this time?”

Wordlessly, Caelus flips the whiteboard. Dan Heng peers at it, brows furrowing.

To his credit, he does properly scrutinise the thing. Caelus assumed he’d take one look at the heading and refuse to read the rest.

Still, Dan Heng’s conclusion is—

“No.”

“Please,” Caelus wheedles. “Dan Heng, hear me out. I can’t do this anymore. First it was Bronya and Seele, and whatever they had going on, which—fine, it was sweet, but I was two months old and didn’t really get it until Natasha pulled me aside and explained it to me. Which was mortifying, by the way.”

Dan Heng looks like he wants to interrupt, so Caelus puts a finger on his lips. His eyes go adorably cross-eyed. *Cute.*

“You weren’t here for this, but I also had to sit through Acheron and Black Swan and their *constant tension* and it kind of felt like being in the middle of a weird dance, except I was the floor getting stepped on.” Dan Heng looks at him reproachfully, so Caelus moves his finger away. “And of course, there was you and Jing Yuan—”

“What,” Dan Heng sputters.

“And Blade, too, now that I think about it—”

“Caelus—”

“—but *these two*,” Caelus groans, flopping backwards onto the floor, “are somehow worse than all of them combined.”

He truly can’t take it anymore. In no universe should he have to witness Mydei’s hand linger on Phainon’s shoulder for a moment longer than what two friends consider proper, and then watch as Mydei flexes his hand right afterwards, clearly so *affected* by it. Like something straight out of March’s romance novels.

Seriously, Phainon’s eyes had *softened* when he looked at Mydei. Multiple times. In public! And here Caelus thought eyes could only soften in Jing Yuan fanfiction.

Dan Heng gives him a look. “Phainon and Mydei are good friends. They’re bound to bicker every once in a while.”

Caelus sits up, wholly indignant. “Have you *seen* them,” he demands.

“I have, yes.”

Evidently Dan Heng hasn’t, if he still thinks that they’re only *good friends*.

Caelus grabs his pen, and nearly stabs the whiteboard in his haste to draw up a bullet point list. A blotch of ink lands on his sleeve, but he doesn’t care.

“When we first met, Mydei only spoke to Phainon, because he *literally didn’t even register that we were there,* even though we were right in front of him,*”* Caelus stresses. Bullet point one. “Phainon made me run up a whole electrified stairway just to race Mydei.” Bullet point two. “One in three of our conversations with Phainon involve Mydei. Trust me, I counted them and worked out the average.” Bullet point three. And, for the final, decisive stroke: *“They stare at each other’s lips even when I’m right there* but I’m too short to do anything about it so really, I’m just standing there staring up at their tits the whole time. While they flirt with each other. *Like I’m not even there.”*

Dan Heng pauses. “Are you… jealous?” he asks, mouth pursed.

Caelus blinks at him. “What? No, definitely not.” Objectively, they’re hot, but he’s not interested. “I just need to get rid of this ‘Doomed Third Wheel’ curse, because otherwise it’ll probably follow me into the next planet. And then I’d have to die, because there’s only so much one guy can take.”

For some reason, Dan Heng visibly relaxes. “You won’t be dying any time soon,” he says, seriously. “And while perhaps Mydei and Phainon are closer than most friends, whether or not they’re more than that is hardly any of our business.”

“Do close friends bathe together?” Caelus asks, seriously. “Like that?”

Dan Heng opens his mouth, considers, and then closes his mouth. He looks slightly mollified.

Bingo. Now for the hook, line, and…

“I just don’t want to be a third wheel anymore,” Caelus despairs. He flutters his lashes. This is bound to work. “Is that so much to ask for?”

“You’re not a third wheel,” Dan Heng tells him, unimpressed.

Flutter, flutter. “March wouldn’t do this to me,” Caelus whines.

Dan Heng, the cheater, turns away from him. “If there truly is something going on between them, then we shouldn’t interfere. They deserve their privacy.”

He said ‘we’, *not* ‘you’, Caelus thinks hopefully, before Dan Heng casually crushes his hopes by settling into his lounge chair and taking out a book.

No amount of badgering gets him to budge. Caelus slinks back to his whiteboard, and mournfully erases his list.

Fine. He doesn't need Dan Heng's help. He can just… wait until Dan Heng decides to help him of his own accord (and he definitely will, because Dan Heng can never leave him to his own devices for too long before he starts to worry, since he's sweet like that). Caelus just has to pester him some more until he gives in.

Until then, Caelus can make a plan.

He uncaps his pen.

CAELUS AND DAN HENG'S

"Leave my name out of it," Dan Heng says, flipping the page of his book without even looking at the whiteboard.

"Boo," Caelus grumbles.

CAELUS' ~~AND DAN HENG'S~~ INFALLIBLE 10 STEP PLAN TO ~~STOP BEING A THIRD WHEEL~~ GET PHAINON AND MYDEI TOGETHER BEFORE A) CAELUS GOES CRAZY B) THEY DIE C) BOTH???

Current Tropes:

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Plans that May or May Not Work (Please Let Them Work)

1. The CLASSIC: set up individual hangouts with both of them and then DITCH so it becomes a date

This plan is, by far, the easiest trick in the book.

Sure, Caelus has been crouching behind this column for so long that his legs are starting to cramp, and there's a chance that the plan might go up in flames because he forgot to eat lunch and it's game over if his stomach growls right now. But this position also grants him the perfect vantage point from which he can watch his immaculate scheme slowly unfold.

Case in point:

Phainon strides into the training grounds. He looks around for a moment, confused, before brightening up (like a *puppy,* Caelus thinks) when his gaze lands on the only other occupant in the area.

“Mydei!” Phainon calls, brightly. “You wouldn’t happen to have seen the Trailblazer around here, would you?”

Mydei turns around, and regards Phainon with a curious look. “No. I was looking for him myself,” he says. “He invited me to a spar.”

“Strange. He invited me to a spar, too,” Phainon says. He raises an eyebrow, and grins. “Looks like one of us got our schedules mixed up. Forgetting things in your old age, Mydei?”

Mydei crosses his arms. If Caelus squints, he can just about make out the vein in his forehead pulsing.

“I’m immortal, not an invalid,” Mydei retorts. “And you’re one to talk, Deliverer. I recall that you couldn’t remember a single date in our history lessons. Are you sure that your memory isn’t so atrocious that you simply forgot your appointment?”

Phainon places a hand on his chest, mock-offended. “Hey, what do my academics have to do with this?” he complains. “I could very well say that you probably got *your* appointment wrong, given your abysmal mathematics. Did you ever learn to read the time in the end, Mydei, or is that skill still beyond you?”

Even from this distance, the fondness in Phainon’s sly smile is striking. Still, Caelus manages to pinpoint the exact moment that the vein in Mydei’s head figuratively pops.

“Enough of this,” Mydei growls. He shifts into a fighting stance, feet set squarely apart and fists raised. “Why don’t we settle this here, fair and square?”

At that, Phainon throws his head back and laughs. It's a relaxed, carefree sound. Almost boyish, even, in a way that Caelus hasn’t quite heard from Phainon before.

“Your words are music to my ears,” Phainon promises, before he summons his blade.

Oh shit, Caelus thinks. He ducks behind the column, right before a resounding *boom* reverberates through the training grounds, the force of it nearly throwing him into the air and crashing into the opposite street.

And thus begins the world’s most protracted form of foreplay.

Caelus rubs his hands together eagerly. If all goes to plan, by the end of today there’ll be one more couple walking around Okhema, and he will finally be able to rest.

All does not go to plan.

It's been over two hours. Caelus' legs are going numb, his trusty column is about to crumble, and he's starting to suspect that the only reason he hasn't been found out yet is because Mydei and Phainon have tunnel vision for each other, and the peripheral vision of a dromas for anyone else.

The pair trade blows in the skilful way that only those that know each other intimately do. Caelus watches, mostly tired but also fascinated, as Mydei caves craters into the floor with his indomitable strength, and as Phainon swiftly dodges his blows, only to return them with equal fervour. The ease with which they respond to each other feels almost like watching a pair of birds in flight, or the push-pull of the tide and the moon. Caelus thinks that he's never seen anything like it.

Neither of them have stayed their attacks, even for a second. The intensity in their gazes, trained wholly on each other, makes Caelus almost feel like he's intruding.

Carefully, Caelus peeks around the column. The sight almost makes him weep.

Phainon is laughing again. He's loud, genuine, and wild, teeth bared and eyes blazing—even when Mydei grabs him by the collar and slams him into the ground.

"I win," Mydei says, smugly. He shifts, looming over Phainon like a dark shadow, and—okay, now he's straddling Phainon's waist and physically pinning him to the ground. "Enlighten me, Deliverer. What's the score now?"

Beneath Mydei, Phainon's chest heaves. His shirt is riding up, soaked with sweat and revealing a swathe of skin. He's gazing at Mydei, mouth parted, and Caelus is sure that his eyes are dilated.

The look of love, Caelus thinks, wistfully. If only he was closer to confirm it for himself.

"Who knows?" Phainon says, breathlessly. "I wouldn't count your victory quite so soon, Mydei."

There's a flash of movement. Before Mydei can respond, Phainon places a hand on his bare waist, and *squeezes.*

Mydei freezes. The way his face contorts with shock is almost comical. His mouth makes an 'O' shape, and his cheeks redden rapidly. Phainon probably has no time to pray, so Caelus places a hand over his heart and sends a prayer up to Kephale for him.

"You and your conniving schemes," Mydei snarls, going straight for Phainon's throat.

Expertly, Phainon dodges. He leaps to his feet, and grins wolfishly. "What about them? They help even the odds against a man with your constitution, do they not—?"

Mydei pivots, picks up a nearby table, and launches it at Phainon's head.

Luckily, Phainon ducks. Unluckily, Caelus has approximately half a second to realise that the table is headed his way before he can throw himself to the side, and watch, miserably, as it demolishes his trusty column.

Their match goes on for hours. By the end of it, Caelus' eyes are drooping with fatigue, and even then the two of them are still going somehow.

He had really expected Phainon and Mydei to spar, press their sweaty bodies against each other and then hopefully make out. Instead, Mydei had been so focused on throttling Phainon that he didn't even notice that he'd nearly beheaded Caelus with a table. Hell, Caelus wouldn't be surprised if neither of them remembered their original reason for coming to the training grounds.

He doesn't want to admit defeat. He really, *really* doesn't want to admit defeat. But his eyes feel like someone glued them shut, and even he's not delusional enough to pretend that this is going anywhere beyond—well. Homoerotic sparring.

Caelus sniffs, pathetically. March's novels *lied* to him.

Surely, though, more good things will come to those who wait, and to those who get a full eight hours of sleep, background battle noises and manly yelling be damned.

So Caelus treks back to his and Dan Heng's room. While he's dragging his feet, he comes to realise, in order, three things:

1. The sparring-aka-foreplay is normal for them, and won't change any time soon.
2. His methods need to be more direct.
3. But before that, he needs intel.

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2. Get them to talk about their feelings

Caelus finds Phainon in the Chrysos Heirs' private dining room, peering down at his dinner with a wry smile.

At least, Caelus *thinks* it's his dinner. The substance in his bowl is as black as tar, with pieces of what looks like regurgitated cat food floating ominously on the surface.

He had no idea Phainon was such a terrible cook. He'd assumed the man was perfect at everything, but apparently even peerless Deliverers have their flaws.

The substance is also bubbling. Caelus wonders, briefly, if it's sentient, before making a mental note to never eat Phainon's cooking if the man offers.

"... What happened?" Caelus asks, genuinely curious.

Phainon laughs. "I may or may not have made a poor choice of wording earlier today," he admits, "and compromised my only chance for a safe dinner. Which I am truly sorry about, by the way—" here, he raises his voice, and looks pointedly towards the kitchen— "but alas, my apology falls on deaf ears."

Caelus blinks. "Do you want me to get you something from the Diner?"

"No need," Phainon tells him. He taps the substance with his fork. It actually *belches* at him. "I think that would actually piss him off more."

Caelus doesn't understand, but he presses on anyway.

"Phainon," Caelus says, very seriously. He leans forward, and clasps his hands together. "This is really important. I need you to tell me your honest opinion of Mydei."

Phainon cocks his head to the side. Like this, he almost looks like an adorable, overgrown puppy. “What brought this on?” he asks. “Is this about the food? Because if so, you should know that this isn’t a universal experience. Your dinner will remain safe and in capable hands, I swear.”

“No, it’s not that,” Caelus says, confused as to why they’re still talking about Phainon’s dinner. “It’s just that…”

He trails off, because either his eyesight is playing tricks on him, or that’s Dan Heng lingering outside the window, softly petting a chimera perching on his head.

Caelus feels a rush of incredulity. Dan Heng won’t help him out, but he’ll still eavesdrop? For shame!

“Just that?” Phainon prompts.

Caelus shakes himself out of his stupor. As he does, an idea slowly begins to form in his head, and he has to suppress the urge to grin.

“It’s just that… Dan Heng keeps up an archive,” he says, smoothly. “And he’s been getting… antsy, recently, because he normally documents everything we encounter on our travels, but for Mydei he’s got barely anything.”

Through the window, Dan Heng stiffens.

“It’s making him stressed,” Caelus lies. “He keeps pacing in our room. I fear that if he doesn’t get any information soon, he’ll start—stress-knitting, or something. And you really don’t want to see what he gets like when he starts stress-knitting.”

At that, Dan Heng turns around slowly. He gives Caelus a Look. The chimera on his head yawns, and curls up to sleep, like a little woollen hat.

Caelus laughs under his breath. Payback has never been so sweet.

“Well, we can’t have that, have we?” Phainon beams. “Although I admit that I’m curious to see exactly how many scarves Dan Heng can knit in one go.”

They’re not really scarves. They’re more like deformed blobs, Caelus thinks. But they’re Dan Heng’s creations that he painstakingly works on and it took *ages* to get him to open up about his new hobby, so by default, Caelus is very fond of those deformed blobs.

“Please, I’m begging you. For Dan Heng’s sake and our own, tell me something that I can pass on to him.”

“Hmm.” Phainon leans back in his chair. “Well… I’m not sure what information would be best suited for Dan Heng’s archive, but Mydei is a commendable warrior. He is an excellent crown prince, and will make an even better king—of that I have no doubt, despite the heavy burden he carries.”

Then, Phainon grins. “But that’s all the boring stuff. Let me tell you about the *real* Mydei.” He crooks a finger and beckons Caelus closer. Caelus leans in eagerly. “Mydei’s actually quite knowledgeable about flowers. He enjoys playing with children, and if there’s no one around, he’ll let them braid flowers into his hair.” Phainon’s expression grows fond. “He’s also a huge bookworm. You might not believe it if you judge him by first glance, but his historical knowledge is impressive. But he also enjoys reading other books—just the other day I found him reading a saucy novella that even the old ladies of Okhema would blush at. And he defended it!” He laughs. “Apparently, even badly written erotica makes for engaging social commentary if you indulge enough.

“But most of all, he’s incredibly funny to rile up. I’d recommend you give it a go. Hardly a day goes by where we’re not taunting each other. I’m actually ahead of him right now in our current competition, by the way, and you should definitely tell him that.”

“Cool,” Caelus says, mind whirring like a machine gone berserk with this new information, “cool. Anything else?”

Phainon smiles at him knowingly. “My friend, it seems like you’re fishing for something.”

Oh, he’s definitely caught on. Fortunately, Caelus has covered all his bases.

He switches to the puppy eyes. “It’s for Dan Heng,” he explains, mouth purposefully wobbling. “I can’t go back to him empty handed. His disappointed face would break my heart.”

Phainon stares at him. Then, his eyes widen.

“Is that how it is? I see.” For some reason, he looks more at ease. He tilts his head back, and looks up at the sky. “Well, at risk of repeating myself, Mydei is a good friend and a worthy rival.” Then, more quietly: “He understands me better than I understand myself.”

With those profound parting words, Caelus thanks him and leaves. He wills himself to walk normally towards the exit, because the newfound knowledge of how deeply Phainon truly understands Mydei nearly has him skipping out of the dining hall in his glee.

When Caelus chances one last glance back, he catches Phainon gazing softly down at his dinner again. How poetic: to be so lovestruck that even a meal as nauseating as *that* can’t distract him from the object of his affections. Caelus notes this down with utmost approval.

This plan is becoming a resounding success, if he does say so himself.

Caelus finds Mydei brooding on a rooftop in Marmoreal Market.

He watches Caelus clamber up the stairs and huff and puff across the canopies with the same look one gives a dying rat in the depths of an alleyway. Once Caelus finally catches up to him, Mydei sighs.

“Usually, when someone stands alone, they do so for a reason,” he says, gruffly.

He still moves aside to make space for Caelus, though, so Caelus counts that as a win.

“Noted,” Caelus says, cheerily. “But I actually came here to talk to you about something important.”

Mydei inclines his head. “Go on.”

“I need your honest opinion on Phainon. For reasons.”

“And what would those reasons be?”

Like he’d done with Phainon, Caelus explains about Dang Heng and his data bank.

“I can’t go back without anything,” he says. “Dan Heng would be sad.”

That’s a lie. At worst, he’d probably just sulk, but Mydei doesn’t have to know that.

Mydei looks him up and down. It’s hard to tell what he’s thinking, because his brow is as furrowed as usual and he looks as serious as ever, but Caelus still puts on his most convincing ‘kicked-puppy’ look. It must work, because a strange look of understanding dawns on Mydei’s face, before he begins to speak.

“The Deliverer is a fool,” he says, slowly. “He always needs someone to watch his back. He may trust his heart to guide him, but if he doesn’t keep it in check, it will become his downfall.”

Caelus opens his mouth, confused, but Mydei interrupts him before he can say a word.

“He is also the only one capable of keeping up with me, and his skills are peerless. Okhema is as safe as it will ever be in his hands.”

Caelus closes his mouth, feeling strangely touched. He hadn’t been expecting such praise from Mydei—not outright, at least. He’d thought the process would be more like pulling a chew toy out of an angry dog’s mouth.

“Anything else?” he prompts.

Mydei levels him with a look that puts the fear of Nikador into his legs and turns them to jelly. “If you want to know more about him, you should ask him, instead of coming to me. Better yet, observe him in battle, or spar with him yourself.”

I don’t want to ask him, I want to ask YOU about him, Caelus wails, internally.

“Understood,” he says, instead.

Mydei turns his back on him, and Caelus takes that to be universal Mydei-speak for ‘I’m done here, go bother someone else’. And leave to bother another unlikely soul he does, until he remembers Phainon’s parting words to him in the dining hall.

Caelus turns on his heel. “Also, he says that he’s currently winning in your ‘current competition’?” he calls after Mydei, “whatever that means. Just thought I’d let you know.”

For a long moment, Mydei simply looks at him, gaze inscrutable. Caelus wonders whether his meddling really has gone too far.

Then, Mydei snorts, and mutters a word that Caelus doesn’t quite understand.

“He may be in the lead for now, but he won’t last long,” Mydei smirks. “I will overtake him eventually.”

Caelus leaves Mydei on that rooftop, watching as he gazes into the distance with a self-satisfied smile.

Dan Heng rounds on Caelus the minute he enters their room.

“I told you not to drag me into this,” Dan Heng says, exasperated. “And *stress-knitting?* Really? Of all things?”

“Sorry, I panicked,” Caelus apologises. He reaches out, and pats Dan Heng’s hand. “But I hardly dragged you into this because you were *clearly* listening in—don’t pretend you weren’t! And you can’t deny that we got crucial information out of those conversations.”

Dan Heng huffs, but he doesn’t deny the accusation. “And what were you planning to do with that information?”

“You’ll see,” Caelus winks. “Everything’s being set into motion. We just need to sit back and wait.”

Three days later, Caelus finds Mydei tenderly dressing Phainon’s wounds and scolding him angrily, while Phainon leans back into his chest and complains.

Caelus decides that he no longer has it in himself to wait.

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2. ~~Get them to talk about their feelings~~ too slow
3. 7 mins in amphorean heaven

Fine—Caelus can admit that this one's a bit drastic, but in his defence, any other sane person would also have snapped by now.

Also, all good things come to those who don't wait. Also also, this method has had a 100% success rate in every novel he's ever read, so.

He simply needs to remove himself from the equation first. For his own personal safety.

"This is a mission of the utmost importance," Caelus says, gravely. "All you have to do is shut the armoury door once they're inside. If you do this for me, you can have ten of my treasure chests."

"Where's the fun in that?" Bartholos complains. "Fine. But I'll only do it for twenty."

"Hell no. I can do fifteen."

“You drive a hard bargain… Eighteen?” Bartholos pouts at him. Their round purple head bobs and somehow dislocates from their body, floating away into the air. “Why do I have to do it, anyway? Why can’t you do it?”

That would be because he doesn’t want Mydei to kill him. Or for Dan Heng to smack him upside the head again, once he inevitably finds out. Or for Aglaea to try executing them—for real, this time.

Caelus draws himself to his full height, and summons his best Aventurine impression. “Sixteen or nothing,” he says, imperiously.

Bartholos bobs in the air, considering. “Deal,” they finally say, and Caelus watches as they whizz into the air, fly in front of the armoury door, and slam it shut.

“What—”

“Hey!”

The door rattles, like someone’s rammed their shoulder against it. Caelus bites his nails anxiously, and wills the door to stay put.

“It’s seriously locked?” Phainon complains, muffled from the other side.

“And who was it that reinforced the lock?” Mydei says, equally as muffled. “Stand aside.”

There’s another *bang.* The door shudders, and a dense cloud of dust billows down from the hinges.

“What did you *do* to this door,” Mydei growls.

“Ah…” Knowing him, Phainon’s sheepishly rubbing the back of his head. “I might have used a—well. I was testing a strength tincture when I was repairing it. At least we know that it works?”

The silence that follows is astronomical. Caelus winces.

“... Anyway! I’ve messaged the others. Someone should be along to rescue us any time soon,” Phainon says, quickly. “In the meantime, what do you say to another competition, Mydei?”

“Hmph.” A rustle of clothes. “... What are you thinking of?”

“Hmm…” There’s the sound of retreating footsteps, before Phainon’s voice calls out. He sounds fainter this time, and Caelus has to inch closer to properly understand his words. “First one to organise all these wins?”

“Is that it?” Mydei laughs. “In that case, I hope you’re prepared to lose.”

Phainon’s probably smirking. Something crashes from inside the armoury; they must have already started. “On the contrary, I think I’ll be walking away with another win tonight, Your

Highness.”

“Don’t call me that.”

… If Caelus weren’t eavesdropping right next to the door, he’d groan out loud. Instead, he drags a hand down his face, and sighs.

Are they seriously just organising swords? Is it too much to ask for them to do anything remotely romantic?! Or for them to fuck? Or do anything non-platonic?

Apparently not. Caelus sighs, barely audible over the clangs and crashes sounding from inside the armoury, and settles in to wait.

“Hah! I win!” Phainon exclaims, barely three minutes later. “That’s 674 to me, if I recall correctly.”

“Not quite,” Mydei rumbles. He sounds pleased. “It seems your senses failed you this time, Deliverer. Look: I win this round.”

Caelus groans, and tries to tune out the sounds of bickering in the background. According to his novels, Mydei and Phainon should at least be making out by now. Instead, they’re neck deep in another competition and someone’s on their way to let them out anyway, which means that Caelus bribed sixteen treasure chests away for no reason.

“What?!” Phainon is whining. He stomps away from the door. There’s a moment of silence, before he grumbles. “Ugh. Fine. I suppose this round is yours, Mydei.”

A bark of laughter. “You would have won, had you not taken the time to appraise each sword in the midst of arranging them.”

“It’s called *multitasking.* I can arrange as well as appreciate the beauty of our weapons—a skill that you’re sorely lacking, might I add—”

Maybe Caelus should’ve forced their proximity by finding a small cupboard to cram them into, instead of the armoury. Or maybe, the two of them are simply beyond standard tropes. Which would mean that he needs to get back to the whiteboard immediately, and brainstorm more plans that don’t just rely on tropes.

Which is difficult, because all Caelus knows *are* tropes.

“—we have some time before Hyacine gets here,” Phainon is saying in the background, while Caelus desperately wracks his head for ideas. His tone is conversational. “And I don’t know about you, Mydei, but I’m feeling quite spry. What say you to another round?”

“... What are you suggesting?”

“Well, we could organise the artillery,” Phainon muses, “but I was thinking that we should continue from where we left off last time.”

Caelus scowls. Really? Another round of sword organisation? *Really?*

Mydei, for his part, sounds decidedly interested. “How bold. Do you truly think you can finish before someone comes knocking?”

“Is that a challenge, Mydei?” Aeons, even the way Phainon deliberately rolls Mydei’s name, almost like he’s purring it, makes Caelus want to hurl. “Let’s make a wager, then. Whoever gives in first, loses. Think you can handle that?”

“Given your performance last time?” Caelus imagines that Mydei’s probably smirking, now. “Easily.”

This sounds like a weird sex thing, Caelus thinks mournfully, *except it’s just them rearranging weapons, instead of each other's guts.*

Yeah, there’s no point in him staying. What a shame.

He turns to leave—

“Mngh—!”

—and nearly trips face-first into the ground instead.

What the *fuck.* Unless he’s gravely mistaken—and he had better not be—that sounded suspiciously like—

He barely gets time to register any of it, before he gets interrupted by another moan. It’s longer, this time, and filthier, too—like the recipient’s *thoroughly* enjoying himself.

Oh Aeons, it is *a weird sex thing,* Caelus thinks wondrously, before: *YES. YESSSSSSSSSSS!!!*

Delighted, he shuffles closer to the door. Not to be a voyeur or anything, because he’s read enough books now to know that’s a bit strange, but he does have to confirm that his plan’s actually worked before he can run away and tell Dan Heng the good news.

“Ngh—you’re being so sweet today,” Phainon pants. There’s a hint of frustration in his tone. “Any reason for that, Mydeimos?”

“I’m being *courteous,”* Mydei grouses. “And you talk too much.”

Then, Phainon makes a choking sound—almost like someone’s shoved their fingers into his mouth.

Ah. Caelus flushes.

... Gauntlet or no gauntlet? he kind of wants to ask, but he values his life (and his correctly-working PLAN) too much.

“Turn around,” Mydei orders, voice low.

“Mmm. Make me.”

Phainon's voice is sultry, and his words are slightly muffled. He *definitely* has Mydei's fingers in his mouth.

"So cocky. You're in no position to be making demands," Mydei hums. "But you enjoy that, don't you?"

Phainon's responding gasp is *loud.* He's been loud this entire time, but now it sounds like he's pressed right up against the door. Wet smacking sounds fill the air: the sound of two mouths crashing together, maybe, or lips trailing down someone's neck. It's such a contrast against the quietness of the training grounds outside that Caelus is frankly shocked that no-one's overheard them yet.

One of them moans, again. There's a gulping sound, and then—gently, progressively becoming more rhythmic—the door begins to shake.

Lucky bastard, Caelus thinks enviously, as Phainon chants Mydei's name like a fervent prayer.

"Mydei—*Mydei—ngh*—Mydeimos, *please—"*

"That's it," Mydei murmurs, almost soft, almost affectionate. "I knew you'd give in. If only you could see yourself, Deliverer." At that, Phainon's breath pitches higher, almost to a soft whine. "Remind me—what's the score now?"

"Ngh—still—still 674—you haven't won this round yet—*ah—!"*

"Really?"

A *slap,* then, reminiscent of the sensual slide of skin against skin. Someone grunts. Then, a metallic *clink* drowns out both noises, like the sound a belt makes when it's being unbuckled with inexperienced hands—or eager ones.

"You underestimate me," Phainon says, breathlessly.

There's a dull thud on the floor, like someone's dropped to their knees. Then, Mydei *groans.* It's guttural and low, and Caelus thinks that they must have switched positions, because what else would explain Mydei's strained pants, and the noise that sounds suspiciously like the back of his head hitting the door?

Caelus takes that as his cue to leave.

He hightails it out of there with a spring in his step. His ten-step plan has just been drastically reduced to three steps, which is probably a world record, if he does say so himself.

Would they appreciate a *'Congrats on the sex!!'* cake? Phainon probably would. Caelus doesn't have the greatest handle on Mydei yet, but he thinks he'd either be thoroughly chewed out (at best) or thoroughly pummelled (at worst). Either way, Caelus has got to consult Dan Heng about all of this.

“Dan Heng!” he shouts, slamming their bedroom door open. “You won’t BELIEVE what I just saw—”

After Caelus finishes recounting everything with great detail, Dan Heng tells him, face pallid: “I really did not want to hear all of that.”

Much later, Caelus finds Phainon feeding the dromases. He waves at him as he approaches, and Phainon puts down a bag of dromas feed to wave back.

“Congrats!” Caelus beams, as soon as he draws near.

“Hello, friend. You look happy,” Phainon says. His voice is suspiciously hoarse. “What is it that I’m supposed to be congratulated about?”

“Your new relationship?” Caelus asks. “You and… Mydei?”

His voice trails off, because Phainon is now looking at him questioningly. “Perhaps I’m not quite following,” Phainon asks slowly, “but what are you talking about?”

Caelus scrabbles wildly for an answer. “Uhh. I may have been walking past the training grounds recently…? And also…”

Sheepishly, he gestures to Phainon’s neck, where a ring of bruises blossoms across his sun tattoo, like a cluster of pressed flowers. Phainon’s gaze follows the line of his finger. He flushes when he realises what Caelus is hinting at, and claps a hand over his neck.

“Oh. That,” Phainon mumbles, cheeks red. “You heard that?”

Caelus nods, feeling far more awkward than this should’ve been. He had been angling for the congratulatory vibe, rather than the embarrassing one.

“I’m afraid you’re mistaken. We aren’t like that,” Phainon explains. “Mydei and I are good friends and rivals. Occasionally, we are … bedmates, yes. But that’s all there is to it. Nothing more.”

… What.

“Oh. Ohhhhh,” Caelus’ mouth says, of its own accord. “... Seriously?”

Phainon nods, and Caelus has to fight the urge to visibly deflate.

He really thought his plan had worked. He supposes that would explain why Mydei and Phainon had fallen for it so easily, like it was second nature, and why Mydei had talked about a ‘last time’. In his excitement, Caelus had ignored both glaring discrepancies.

Phainon smiles at him, strained. Crickets chirp in the background, and Caelus gets the sense that he should leave him be.

“Sorry for bringing that up,” he says, genuinely. “And sorry for assuming. If it helps, no one else really saw or heard anything. I think.”

“It helps,” Phainon says, clapping him on the shoulder. “Thank you, Caelus.”

Caelus leaves the stables feeling like something has gone terribly wrong.

After the Armoury Incident, as he’d dubbed it, Caelus notices that Mydei and Phainon indeed aren’t acting any different. They banter as usual, countering arguments back and forth, and Caelus still feels like he’s third wheeling them whenever he’s within a five-mile radius of the pair, but they definitely don’t seem like they’re in any sort of new relationship. Either Phainon lied and now they’re actually secretly dating (unlikely), or Caelus’ plan failed miserably yet again (unfortunately, very likely).

Which means he needs another plan.

Miserably, he uncaps his pen.

CAELUS’ ~~AND DAN HENG’S~~ INFALLIBLE 10 STEP PLAN TO ~~STOP BEING A THIRD WHEEL~~ GET PHAINON AND MYDEI TOGETHER BEFORE A) CAELUS GOES CRAZY B) THEY DIE C) BOTH???

Current Tropes:

- Rivals to Lovers
- Eyefucking
- Immortal x Mortal
- ????? Profit

- Homoerotic Sparring
- Rivals with Benefits

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3. ~~7 mins in amphorean heaven~~ more like 7 mins in amphorean hell
4. ??? I HAVE NO IDEAS dan heng HELP ME

"Have you ever considered that perhaps you're going about this in the wrong order," Dan Heng says.

He tells him this while Caelus is resting his head on his lap, so Caelus has no choice but to gaze up at Dan Heng's gentle face of disapprovement. Unfair.

"Fine," Caelus huffs. He turns his face the other way, and sighs in contentment when Dan Heng scritches the hair at the base of his neck. "I guess I'll just set them up on another date in the meantime."

Surely, fighting Titankin together would be seen as romantic in the eyes of those two. It might even lead to some hand holding, if they're lucky. Surely.

Caelus realises that the date failed when Phainon storms back to Okhema first, face furious.

"Woah," says Caelus, alarmed. "What happened?"

"Ask *him,"* Phainon snaps. He jabs a thumb behind him, where Mydei is walking calmly along the Path of Parting. "I'll be retiring to my quarters. Sorry."

With that, Phainon stalks off in the direction of Kephale Plaza. The crowds amassed on the path leap aside to make space for him, eyes wide and mouths gaping. Evidently, they're confused by his anger, and Caelus can empathise. He's never seen Phainon look so pissed before.

He turns to Mydei, apprehensive, but Mydei only scoffs. "The Deliverer simply doesn't know his limits," he says, "and remains quick to anger when he is reminded of them." He crosses his arms. "Forget it. He'll come around soon enough."

With that, Mydei turns away. He begins trudging up the same path Phainon took, presumably to report back to Aglaea.

Oh, *hell* no.

Caelus launches forward, and grabs a fistful of Mydei's cloak, stopping him in his tracks.

"What are you doing," Mydei asks him, unimpressed.

"That can't be it," Caelus begs him, pathetically clinging on. "What *really* happened? Please tell me—I feel bad for asking you two to deal with my missions if this is the result."

"Hm," Mydei considers. "No."

Caelus yelps as he gets shrugged off, feeling like a fly getting batted away by a giant hand. Behind him, the crowd snickers. With a sinking feeling, he realises that he's probably secured his spot at tonight's prime gossip fodder.

But the Astral Express did not raise a quitter, so Caelus grits his teeth, scrambles to his feet and chases after Mydei anyway.

It takes the entire evening and then some to wrangle the full story out of him, because the man is determined to report to Aglaea first no matter how desperate Caelus' bribes get. Finally, after much pestering on his end, he gets an abridged version of the entire story.

Apparently, the fight had been going well until Phainon had slipped up, and failed to notice one of the Titankin sneaking up on him from behind. Mydei had taken that fatal hit for him, revived, before proceeding to take two more fatal hits for him, and had then thought the situation so dire that he had bodily chucked Phainon into a safe spot away from the battle, where Phainon then had to watch Mydei die and revive again and again.

Caelus winces. That's rough, but he understands where Mydei's coming from. He would probably do the same if he had the same capabilities. Caelus knows, though, that March and Dan Heng would've given the stink eye if he ever chose to do such a thing.

He reverses the analogy in his head. If Dan Heng had expelled him from battle in order to keep him safe, even though he's perfectly capable of looking after himself, and then proceeded to die over and over again while all Caelus could do was watch… well. Now he understands why Phainon had looked so rattled when they arrived back.

However, he also understands that this gives them the perfect opportunity.

"Don't you see? This is *perfect,"* Caelus gushes, back in the safety of his room. "Phainon's angry because Mydei kept throwing himself in front of him to keep him safe. Now they'll have spectacular bed-breaking makeup sex and tearfully confess their feelings in the dark! Or day, I guess."

Dan Heng is dutifully covering Mem's ears. He looks like he wants to cover his own ears. "Your imagination is vivid."

And that's all he says, no matter how much Caelus pesters him. So, Caelus decides to sit back and wait.

Days pass, and Caelus realises that Mydei and Phainon may or may not have had spectacular bed-breaking makeup sex, but: a) he'll never know, and b) it didn't amount to anything, because by the next week they're already back to normal.

He grits his teeth, muffles his screams into his pillow, and returns—with resentment—to the drawing board.

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5. Love triangle, baby

“Perhaps they’re choosing to keep their relationship private,” Dan Heng offers, drily.

Perhaps they are. But Caelus has a knack for knowing when these things happen, and right now, he’s incredibly sure that the two of them are still just pathetically yearning for each other. Hell, he’d literally seen Mydei press the back of his gauntlet against Phainon’s nape the other day to cool him off after they’d sparred, and say what you will, but Caelus knows those eyes were filled with love.

Anyway, there’s no point in overthinking it, because his next plan will definitely work.

“You want me to teach you to dance?” Phainon asks him, perplexed. “Are you sure? I’m known for having two left feet, you know.”

“Please,” Caelus pleads, clasping his hands together. He scrabbles for an excuse. “There’s—uh—someone I want to impress, and I don’t know who else to ask.”

Phainon stares at him, before suddenly sucking in a deep breath. “Oh. *Oh!”* Phainon winks. “Of course. Say no more—your secret is safe with me.”

Caelus nearly sags in relief. “So where do we start?”

Phainon takes him to Kephale Plaza, and situates him right in the middle of the space. The other people milling around cast them curious glances, but most pay them no mind.

Thankfully, Caelus’ intel was correct, and Mydei’s among that crowd today. From what Caelus can make out from this distance, it also seems like Mydei has a clear line of sight to where he and Phainon are standing.

Excellent.

“Okheman dances are traditionally lively and fast-paced,” Phainon explains, “You’ll know if you’ve danced them properly if you find your head spinning for a full night afterwards. That being said, there are some slow dances reserved specifically for couples, though. I can teach you those first if you’d like, since you’ve said that you’re short for time.”

“Perfect, yes, I definitely want the slow couples’ dance, thank you SO much,” Caelus says distractedly, peering across the clearing to watch as Mydei turns around and stares at them. *Perfect.*

Phainon grins. He extends an arm. “In that case, follow my lead. We’ll get you fighting fit in no time.”

With that, they launch into a dance.

Despite Phainon claiming to have two left feet, he’s actually not so bad. His steps are sure, and he twists and turns with a fluid expertise that Caelus can barely follow along with. Even then, Phainon’s a good teacher. He guides Caelus’ movements with clear instructions and the right amount of physical adjustment, so that he doesn’t end up looking like a flailing chimera that’s run out of both stamina and efficiency.

During a spin, Caelus chances a glance towards Mydei, who is… deep in conversation with Dan Heng, now. He isn't even looking at them.

Caelus huffs. Time to up the ante, it seems.

He deliberately misplaces his foot, not-so-accidentally trips and falls straight into Phainon's waiting arms.

"Oh, no," Caelus laments, snuggling into Phainon's strong grip. "Sorry, I'm just *so* bad at this…"

"Not to worry," Phainon says warmly. He adjusts his grip so that Caelus is more comfortable, before settling him gently on the ground. "Better to make mistakes now, than make them when you're trying to woo your beloved. Although I think that you falling over would endear him more to you than he already is."

Caelus barely hears the tail-end of whatever Phainon says, because he's already out of Phainon's arms and Mydei doesn't give a shit, which is terrible. He scrunches up his face, and wills his eyes to well with tears.

"I think I've broken something," Caelus wails. Gingerly, he sticks out his right foot. "Could you check?"

Phainon frowns. "Really? Well, I guess it could be a sprain… Let me have a look."

Phainon, Caelus learns, is a true gentleman. He checks over Caelus' foot with practiced efficiency, carefully rolling down his socks and running nimble fingers along the length of his ankle and calf. Caelus sits back and pretends to whimper, even as he cracks one eye open and squints in Mydei's general direction.

Mydei *has* to be the jealous type. Any minute now, he'll stalk over and yank Phainon away from Caelus, which will hopefully lead to a long, productive conversation for the two of them. Then, Caelus can finally rest in peace.

"You'll be happy to know that you're fine," Phainon finally announces. He rises to his feet, and gives Caelus a concerned look. "Are you in pain? We can take a break if you'd like."

Caelus cracks the other eye open eagerly, only to find that Mydei is… letting a crowd of squealing children use his biceps as a pull-up bar.

How is *Dan Heng* looking at them with furrowed brows, but not Mydei?

Caelus closes his eyes again. He takes a calming breath.

"... I can keep going," he says, weakly. "Actually, aren't there any other dances I should learn?"

Maybe this one simply isn't sexy enough. Is there an Amphoreus version of a sexy tango?

Phainon laughs. “There are plenty,” he promises. “I’ll teach you all of them, in time. But I think you should focus on this one first, though, so you can impress that special someone.”

The sentence is accompanied by a wink and a nudge. Caelus smiles back, feeling faint.

“I see,” he says. “You know a lot of dances, Phainon. Did you learn all of them here?”

Phainon’s expression shifts, imperceptible. “Mostly. When I was a child, I only knew the most basic harvest rites from Aedes Elysiae. Those were the easiest ones to learn, but they were all group dances, so you’d usually dance along with your neighbours.” Phainon gives him a wan smile. “Unfortunately, I never got to learn any other dances.”

He looks wistful. Tactfully, Caelus changes the subject.

Phainon spends the better part of the Lucid Hour teaching Caelus to dance. In that whole time, Mydei barely looks their way, although he does watch with interest every time Caelus stumbles about and steps on Phainon’s feet.

To be specific, he looks at *Phainon* with interest and barely concealed warmth. There’s no jealousy there, though, no matter how hard Caelus squints.

As Phainon brings their lesson to a close, Caelus tries not to visibly wilt. This is the worst losing streak he’s had in a very long time. Possibly the worst losing streak he’s ever had in his sad, short existence.

“What are you practising for, if I may ask?” Phainon asks, handing Caelus a towel. “Is it an event?”

“You could say that,” Caelus pants, exhausted. “Thanks again, Phainon.”

Phainon waves as he walks away, before quickly bounding over to Mydei and dragging him off towards the markets. Mydei grunts in annoyance as Phainon talks his ear off, but after a while, he actually starts to look like he’s listening.

Caelus waves back, waiting until the pair disappear around the corner. Then, he turns to Dan Heng, who’s giving him a slight, fond smile, and pretends to cry.

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5. ~~Love triangle, baby~~ mydei didn't even LOOK
6. Maybe Phainon's the jealous one???

"What are you doing?" Mydei asks, sounding genuinely perplexed.

Caelus is slowly realising that it is incredibly difficult to look Mydei in the eye when his beautiful, voluptuous chest is directly in front of his face. How does Phainon do this daily, and still manage to summon the brainpower to bicker with him?

Well. If anyone asks, let it be known to all of Amphoreus that Trailblazer Caelus truly blazes a trail.

"Has anyone ever told you—" *that your tits are huge?* Caelus mentally slaps himself—*he's* not trying to get into Mydei's pants, that's *Phainon's* job— "that your tattoos look really—cool?" He coughs. "You should tell me about them."

Mydei gives him a faintly disapproving look, and raises an eyebrow. "Is it not considered rude in your culture to enquire after the bodies of others?"

"I'm only asking because I read about it," Caelus says, loftily. "There was a chapter about royal tattoos in this Kremnoan textbook I found in the Librarium. Everyone I asked about it directed me to you."

While he's speaking, Caelus chances a glance towards the other end of the Garden. Sure enough, Phainon's there. He's leaning against the wall, and staring directly at them with an inscrutable expression.

Caelus has to fight back his grin. *Score.*

"My people were correct in directing you to me. The ones most knowledgeable about our customs are long gone, so those in the Kremnoan detachment wouldn't be able to give you a detailed response," Mydei says, regarding him with grudging respect. "To answer your question: yes, these tattoos are the mark of royal heritage. They first appear on the chest during childhood, and expand rapidly during the adolescent years. By adulthood, the marks will generally have covered the entirety of the torso."

Mydei holds out his arm, and Caelus leans over. To his surprise, the tattoos there almost look like they're glowing.

"My marks are different, however," Mydei continues. "They are as extensive as they are on my body because of the curse I bear. Ordinary royals of the Kremnoan lineage would not have as many tattoos as I do."

"Wow. That's amazing," Caelus breathes, before blurting out: "Can I touch them?"

Mydei gives him a withering look, and Caelus raises his hands apologetically. He really does mean it—ulterior motives aside, Mydei's immortal body is fascinating to him.

Before he can explain himself, though, an icy breeze washes over him. It almost feels like he's back in Belobog again. Caelus shivers, teeth chattering, and watches as Phainon silently materialises next to Mydei.

"Hello, Mydei," Phainon says, with a pleasant smile that doesn't quite reach his eyes. He turns to Caelus. "Trailblazer." Ah, so he's 'Trailblazer' now, not Caelus. *Score.* "You two seem to be having an interesting conversation. May I join?"

Caelus glances down. Phainon's hand is hovering near the small of Mydei's back, protective. He's pressed right along the contours of Mydei's side, leaving little space between them. Mydei doesn't shy away from him, even when Phainon props his chin on Mydei's shoulder and regards Caelus with a cool gaze.

Caelus is *delighted* at this. He also understands acutely that the only way this can get even better is if he gets even worse.

So, when Mydei opens his mouth to respond to Phainon's query, Caelus cuts in, brightly: "Sure! I was just asking Mydei about his tattoos."

"You were?" Phainon's eyes are dark, a hint of a challenge lurking in those depths. He turns to Mydei, and pouts. "Rather chatty today, Mydei, aren't you? When *I* asked about them you brushed me off!"

“That’s because you insisted on badgering me about them while we were in the baths,” Mydei retorts. “And because your knowledge of ancient Kremnoan traditions, even after my tutelage, is abysmal. Unlike you, the Trailblazer knows how to pick up a book and consolidate his own understanding of the topic.”

“I can touch them, right?” Caelus pleads, diverting the attention back onto himself. “Just once?”

Phainon’s free hand twitches. *Can’t a man be curious?* Caelus wants to ask him cheekily, but he holds his breath.

Mydei sighs, long-suffering. “Once,” he acquiesces. “Although I warn you that it feels no different to ordinary skin.”

Caelus cheers, and reaches out a hand. His fingers don’t even get to skim the hair on Mydei’s chest before Phainon’s caught his wrist in a vice-grip.

“Ah, that’s hardly fair,” Phainon says, still smiling. “Mydei’s conspicuous body is priceless, you know. It would hardly be appropriate if anyone could touch it any time they wanted.”

“Really?” Caelus grins. “Well, maybe you should do something about that. Before someone else does.”

Phainon’s eyes flash dangerously, and he throws Caelus a look of betrayal. His hand makes an aborted motion, almost like he wants to bodily drag Caelus from the clearing altogether.

Caelus remembers, then, that although Phainon is a friend that he’s riling up, he’s also an incredibly powerful Chrysos Heir who’s gone toe-to-toe with thousands of Titankin and won. He could probably toss Caelus over the side of Okhema like a sack of potatoes if he wanted.

Ah, well. Caelus rolls his shoulder, and grins.

He’s the Galactic Baseballer. Putting his life on the front line is part of his daily routine. Anything for the rivals to lovers, and all that.

“What’s going on?”

Caelus whips around, and finds Dan Heng striding quickly towards them, his face drawn in confusion. He frowns. Since when did Dan Heng approach so quietly?

“Dan Heng!” Caelus says, surprised. He wonders whether he should explain, since Dan Heng isn’t in on this particular plan, but eventually settles on: *fuck it, I may as well go all in.* “I’m going to touch Mydei’s body.”

With any luck, Phainon will now attempt to kill him, OR yank Mydei back and growl possessively like a dog, OR sweep him into a kiss in front of all of Okhema to make a statement. Caelus isn’t picky. Any will do.

“What,” Mydei sputters, flustered.

“What,” Phainon snarls, gripping Mydei’s waist like a lifeline.

“What.”

Caelus startles, and turns to the source of the last voice. The sight nearly makes him jump.

Dan Heng’s face is decidedly sour. His eyes have narrowed into slits, and he’s staring at Caelus like he’s drinking in the sight of him for the first time in a long time, yet also like he wants Caelus to be as far away from here as possible.

Caelus wracks his brain for answers. Why is Dan Heng angry? He isn’t even supposed to *be* here, and while it’s still not too late to ask him to join in and help, Dan Heng has no idea what the plan is—

“Care to explain?” Dan Heng asks him, frostily.

Caelus wrings his hands, suddenly nervous. “Uh—well. I was asking about Mydei’s tattoos.” Caelus says, lamely. His voice comes out more of a squeak.

Somehow, he feels like he’s done something wrong. But he can’t fathom what it could be, and now the plan’s going awry because of it.

Mydei looks between the three of them, mouth pursed. A look of understanding crosses his face. He presses a palm to his forehead, and turns away.

“Whatever’s going on, leave me out of it. I want no part in this farce.”

The tension in Phainon’s shoulders bleeds out, and he pulls Mydei closer to him. “I agree completely,” he says, voice smooth. “Let’s stop this before it goes any further.”

Noooo, Caelus wants to cry, *I was so close!*

Dan Heng turns to Phainon. “In that case, please let go of Caelus,” he says. His tone indicates that it isn’t a request.

Phainon looks between the two of them, considering. Then, he looks at Mydei. The corner of Mydei’s mouth twitches. Phainon raises an eyebrow in question, and Mydei shrugs a response, which makes Phainon erupt into a shit-eating grin.

Since when could they use telepathy, Caelus thinks, actually impressed—right before Phainon suddenly lets go of Caelus’ wrist, interlocks their fingers, and yanks him forward so far that he nearly crashes into Phainon’s chest.

“I find I rather like it here, actually,” Phainon announces.

Caelus blinks. He sighs, and gives Phainon a deadpan look. Phainon only shrugs at him, before leaning in close. His breath skims hot against the shell of Caelus’ ear.

“Two can play at that game,” he murmurs, voice mischievous.

Caelus rolls his eyes. *Whatever.* He still managed to prove one of his hypotheses, at least. This just means he'll have to return to the whiteboard again. It's no big deal in the long run.

"Come on Dan Heng, let's get going," he says. There's no response. "Dan Heng?"

Frowning at the silence, Caelus looks back—

—only to find Dan Heng staring at the place where his and Phainon's hands are joined, looking downright *murderous*.

Oh *no*.

In an instant, Caelus' priority shifts. Abort mission, abort mission—*please don't shift into your dragon form,* Caelus begs. The wind is already picking up angrily around Dan Heng's heels. If Caelus squints, he can definitely make out a teal glow around Dan Heng's tense shoulders, threatening to burst forth and blind everyone in a five-mile radius if they don't get going *right now.*

It would be really bad if Dan Heng's tail came out and wrapped itself around Caelus' leg again, or if it started storming here, in the land of perpetual daylight, or if he called down the whole of the Xianzhou Alliance to nuke one man.

Not that he would ever do that. He's far too sensible.

Caelus looks at Dan Heng, and reconsiders his statement.

He yanks his hand out of Phainon's grip, and hurriedly drags Dan Heng away. "Thanks for the history lesson, Mydei!" he calls, panicked. "I'll record everything in the data bank!"

Later, Phainon catches up to him, looking every inch like a kicked puppy.

"I really am sorry," he apologises, profusely. "I don't know what came over me."

Caelus waves him off. "Nah, it's fine. All's fair in love and war."

Phainon flushes. "Still, what you saw was a rather—ugly side of me, that no friend should have had to see. I'm sorry for that."

"I told you, it's okay. Honestly, it was kind of funny."

At that, Phainon smiles, looking relieved. "Well, I am grateful to have gained your forgiveness. Should I ever behave like that again, you have my permission to smack the foolishness out of me. Mydei's words, not mine." He looks around. "I also have to apologise

to Dan Heng. I was trying to help him, but I realise that my method was completely out of order."

"Ah…" Caelus trails off awkwardly. How can you explain the concept of an overprotective dragon to someone who has never seen a dragon before? "Maybe come back tomorrow?"

"Understood," Phainon nods. He draws himself up to his full height, suddenly serious. "I will apologise on his terms. Like a man."

Caelus frowns after him. Weird, but okay.

After Phainon's trial and the incident at the Grove, Caelus barely has any time to create more steps for his plan. But he hasn't forgotten about it. He *can't* forget about it—not after he watches as Phainon's expression melts into unguarded relief when Mydei enters the fray against the Flame Reaver, and the two of them seamlessly guard each other's backs with the ferocity and desperation of devotion unending.

Caelus actually thinks that maybe, just maybe, they'll confess their feelings organically, and he can finally lay down the hatchet.

Then, Mydei drops the worst bombshell known to man.

CAELUS' ~~AND DAN HENG'S~~ INFALLIBLE 10 STEP PLAN TO ~~STOP BEING A THIRD WHEEL~~ GET PHAINON AND MYDEI TOGETHER BEFORE A) CAELUS GOES CRAZY B) THEY DIE C) BOTH???

Current Tropes:

- Rivals to Lovers
- Eyefucking
- Immortal x Mortal
- ????? Profit
- Homoerotic Sparring
- Rivals with Benefits

Plans that May or May Not Work (Please Let Them Work)

1. ~~The CLASSIC: set up individual hangouts with both of them and then DITCH so it becomes a date~~ i was stupid every sparring session is a date they just don't know it. also caused criminal damage if aglaea finds out she'll get my ass
2. ~~Get them to talk about their feelings~~ too slow
3. ~~7 mins in amphorean heaven~~ more like 7 mins in amphorean hell
4. ~~date #2~~ ❌❌❌ i give up. Going back to tropes
5. ~~Love triangle, baby~~ mydei didn't even LOOK
6. ~~Maybe Phainon's the jealous one???~~ Success (kind of)
7. WHERE IS MYDEI GOING

"What do you *mean* he's leaving PERMANENTLY," Caelus whisper-yells.

He can't believe it. Firstly, Mydei's his friend now, so he can't just leave. Secondly, how the hell is he leaving without resolving whatever he and Phainon have got going on between them?

Behind him, Dan Heng continues to redress his wounds from their fight with the Flame Reaver. One of the only reasons that they had made it out of that fight intact was because of Mydei's godly intervention.

Mydei, who's about to *leave. Forever.*

"Do you want my honest opinion?" Dan Heng asks. He doesn't wait for Caelus to answer. "I think we should let things run their natural course."

"There is no 'natural course'!" Caelus wails. "He's going to leave, and then he'll never come back, and Phainon will be lonely *forever."* He slumps backwards into Dan Heng's arms, and ignores the resulting huff. "I know I wanted to stop being a third wheel, but not like this."

Dan Heng sets down his bandages. "Caelus. Stop panicking," he says firmly. "He hasn't left yet."

Dan Heng is right, which is why Caelus has dragged him out to find Mydei before he leaves.

For some reason, there's a packed crowd at the Okheman gate. Caelus curses as he ducks and swerves around them. If they're any later, they won't be able to make it in time.

Finally, he spots Mydei at the far end of the road. He's face to face with Phainon. They seem reluctant to look away from each other, and Caelus gets the impression that even if he called

Mydei's name, he'd go unnoticed.

"Caelus, we should—"

"Shh," Caelus hisses, tugging Dan Heng behind a nearby pillar.

"—and I'm going to find out if the Kremnoan language is really missing that many words," Phainon is saying.

Mydei chuckles. "The Kremnoan philosophy can never be encapsulated in a mere dictionary."

He pauses, then. His voice softens. "But… If there's a chance in the next life, you should come visit my library,"

Caelus claps his free hand over his mouth, and resists the urge to gasp. That is, without a doubt, the most romantic thing he's ever heard.

"In another life, huh?" Phainon laughs, mirthlessly. His gaze drops to the floor.

The air turns cold. Caelus feels like someone stole the breath from his lungs. He grabs Dan Heng's hand in a death grip, and after a moment, he feels Dan Heng silently squeeze back.

A complicated expression crosses Mydei's face; some mix of regret and longing, before shifting into weary acceptance. He steps forward into Phainon's space, deliberate and slow.

"Deliverer," he says, voice incredibly gentle. "Phainon. Look at me."

Phainon's gaze stays trained on the floor. His expression is hidden by the bangs that cover his face. It's only when Mydei lifts a gauntleted hand to gently tilt his head back, and cradles his cheek in his palms, that he looks up.

Strange, that the very same gauntlets that had caused so much destruction could caress Phainon's cheek so carefully, like he was something precious. Mydei is a gentle man; Caelus only wishes that he realised it sooner.

"You have your duty, and I have mine," Mydei murmurs, before leaning forward and pressing their foreheads together. *A Kremnoan parting custom,* Caelus recalls, from what he read in that very same textbook he had asked Mydei about.

They stay like that for a while, simply breathing together. Then, Mydei dips his head, and whispers something low in Phainon's ear.

Caelus doesn't hear what he says. For once, he doesn't want to hear it, either. Somehow, he feels like he's intruded enough.

Whatever Mydei's words are, though, they make Phainon crumple.

"Mydei…" Phainon breathes, sounding positively heartbroken. He winds his arms around Mydei's back and draws him impossibly closer, hands hovering near that same spot at his

spine that he always seems to favour. His eyes are very bright. “You’re a cruel man, you know that?”

KISS, Caelus screams internally. *KISS!!*

Even Dan Heng’s invested. He’s closing his eyes and making a pained face, but his grip is deathly.

Eventually, the pair draw apart. They move slowly and reluctantly, hands lingering like they want to map every inch of the other’s skin. Finally—and to Caelus’ growing horror—Mydei tucks one stray strand of hair behind Phainon’s ear, nods, and turns around.

“May triumph always follow you, Mydeimos,” Phainon calls after him. His voice trembles, but he manages to keep it together.

Slowly, Mydei’s figure grows smaller, until he’s no bigger than a speck of crimson in the distance. Phainon waits until he’s no longer visible, before raising a hand to scrub at his eyes.

And that’s the end of that.

…

“Oh, hell no,” Caelus growls, leaping out behind the cover of the pillar. Phainon only has time to yelp, before Caelus starts to haul him away. “What do you mean, ‘in another life’—”

CAELUS’ ~~AND DAN HENG’S~~ INFALLIBLE 10 STEP PLAN TO ~~STOP BEING A THIRD WHEEL~~ GET PHAINON AND MYDEI TOGETHER BEFORE A) CAELUS GOES CRAZY ~~B) THEY DIE C) BOTH???~~ WHY NOT THIS LIFE??????

“That sentence doesn’t even make sense anymore,” Dan Heng points out.

Caelus ignores him, and miserably adds ‘doomed yaoi’ to the tropes list.

“What is ‘yaoi’?” asks Phainon.

“Don’t worry about it,” Dan Heng tells him hastily.

Phainon leans over to inspect the whiteboard more closely. The more he reads, the higher his eyebrows climb, until Caelus starts to think that they might disappear into the snowy peaks of his hair altogether.

“Wait,” Phainon says, slowly. He’s sat cross-legged on their bedroom floor, looking slightly incredulous. “Is this what you were doing all this time?”

To his credit, Dan Heng does try to explain, but Caelus beats him to it.

“You have no idea,” Caelus tells him gravely. *“No* idea.”

Phainon blinks at him. He looks at the whiteboard again, and then back at Caelus, mouth agape.

“Not that I’m not flattered, but this level of detail is really quite remarkable… and slightly scary.” He pauses. “So *that’s* why you were trying to feel up Mydei’s chest?”

“...”

Caelus looks pointedly at the far wall. Phainon rounds on Dan Heng.

“And you were fine with that, Dan Heng?”

“I had no idea of Caelus’ plans,” Dan Heng sniffs, “because I refused to be involved in them.”

“But now you are?”

“... but now I am.”

“Stop deflecting!” Caelus cries. “Let’s get back to the topic at hand. Why did you two break up?”

“It’s hardly ‘breaking up’ if we were never together in the first place,” Phainon says, with a wry smile.

Caelus throws up his hands in disbelief. “That’s the point! Why did you never get together? You clearly care about each other, you clearly want each other—hell, half of Okhema has a betting pool going on the last time I checked—but still, you two never got together!”

“Hah! I knew there was a betting pool,” Phainon chuckles. He stretches out a leg, and grows pensive. “You’re right about the rest, though. We do care about each other.”

Then, Phainon pauses. “Actually, we did discuss whether we should announce a formal courtship, or even pin an official name to our relationship. But in the end, we decided against it.”

The admission makes Caelus’ head spin. For once, he is at a loss for words. “But why…?”

Phainon sighs, world-weary. “Mydei is fighting back the black tide as we speak. The chances of him being able to leave Castrum Kremnos are near zero. It’s a thankless battle, and he’ll keep fighting until he buckles under the burden of Strife, or until…” Phainon stops, a complicated expression crossing his face, “he no longer has to.

“That’s probably not what you wanted to hear, but it’s the truth. And I have my own duties as a Chrysos Heir. If I abandoned the Flamechase Journey for my own heart, Mydei would never let me hear the end of it.”

“Can you not visit?” Dan Heng asks.

Phainon startles. “What?”

“Castrum Kremnos. Could you not visit Mydei there?”

At that, Phainon hunches in on himself. “I’ve thought about it,” he admits. “Many a night. More than I should. But whatever the outcome, I would have to return to Okhema eventually. And with our duties, who knows when I will be able to visit Castrum Kremnos again?” He turns to gaze out of the balcony window, into the eternal dawn and beyond. “I am not so cruel a man as to reciprocate his feelings, before leaving him to be condemned to an eternity of bloodshed.”

Caelus frowns. “I don’t buy that,” he argues. “You two deserve happiness. Even if it’s fleeting. Why wait for the next life when this one’s still kicking?” He turns to his companion. “Right, Dan Heng?”

“I agree,” Dan Heng nods. “If there’s ever a chance, you should cherish those dearest to you, and hold them close now.”

Caelus feels his heart grow warm. Dan Heng, of all people, would know the most about this. If only he could explain to Phainon why.

Phainon picks at a thread on the rug. “Even if we’re fated to be apart for the rest of our days?” he asks quietly.

Caelus thinks of March, ever a steadfast companion and confidante even when he wound her up; of Welt and Himeko, who offered him a home when he had none; of Pom-Pom, who made sure to cheer him up even when he made more of a mess in the Parlor Car than help; and of Dan Heng, who has saved him more times than he can count. If Caelus lost even one of them in this lifetime without letting them know the depths of his gratitude, he’s certain that the devastation would be too much for him to bear.

“Even then,” Caelus nods. “Besides, there are far worse long-distance relationships. Mnestia and Cerces were a tree and butterfly. You literally cannot get more long distance than that.”

At that, Phainon finally laughs. It’s not like one of his pleasant facades he’d been putting on since Caelus had dragged him to their room. Instead, it’s a full laugh, right from the belly, leaving Phainon clutching his stomach as he tries to compose himself.

Caelus smiles. It’s about time he made his friend laugh properly.

“You make compelling arguments,” Phainon says, wiping his eyes. “I wonder what Mydei would say if he heard them? In all honesty, he’d probably insult me.” He climbs to his feet, and dusts off his clothes. “But… thank you. You’ve given me a lot to think about.”

Caelus claps him on the back. “Sometimes you need an outsider’s perspective,” he says, straight-faced, “before you can undoom yourselves from the narrative. And then you can put the wedding back on!”

Phainon smiles at him with the distinct air of someone who has no idea what Caelus just said, and claps him on the shoulder. “Can I ask one last question before I go?”

“Shoot.”

“May I ask why you’re so invested?” Phainon asks. “You’ve already assisted Amphoreus greatly, and while I’m immensely grateful for your assistance, I can’t help but think that we have barely anything of equivalent value to offer when it comes to matters like this.”

Caelus doesn’t miss a beat. “I need to break my curse,” he tells him, completely seriously, and refuses to respond when Phainon tries to push further.

A few days later, Phainon seeks out Caelus in the Marmoreal Market, and pulls him aside into a secluded corner.

“I’ve been thinking about what you two have told me,” Phainon says, slowly. “I think I’ve decided.”

“And…?” Caelus asks, heart in his throat.

“And I think I will visit him,” Phainon says, the corners of his mouth tugging into a smile. “It will probably be painful, and there will come a time where we’ll have to say goodbye to each other for good, but I’ve decided that’s a risk that I’m willing to take.” Phainon reaches out, and grasps Caelus’ hand. His eyes, usually so piercing, are painfully sincere. “I have to thank you and Dan Heng both, for talking some sense into me.”

“Any time,” Caelus whispers back fiercely.

The relief is so palpable that it makes Caelus feel weak in the knees. He feels weaker than when Mydei had glared at him on the roof that one time.

It’s only when Phainon has clearly rounded the corner and been gone for a few minutes that Caelus lets out a large *whoop,* and dashes back into his room to tell Dan Heng the good news.

Phainon departs the very next day. Caelus and Dan Heng decide to accompany him.

Once they reach the gate, however, Phainon throws out an arm and stops them from walking forward.

“One moment,” he says.

Phainon walks, leaving Caelus and Dan Heng exchanging confused glances behind. He positions himself squarely in the centre of the road and tips his head back, surveying the clear expanse of the sigh.

Phainon breathes deeply. Once, twice, and then—

“Mydeimos!” Phainon shouts, loud and clear. “Can you hear me?”

For a long moment, Caelus stays confused. He has no idea what Phainon’s doing, calling out Mydei’s full name like the man can hear him all the way from Castrum Kremnos—

BOOM.

Caelus yelps, and instinctively throws up a hand to cover his face. A beam of scarlet flashes from behind his hand and illuminates the sky. In the distance, thunder rumbles. Somehow, the sound is almost comforting.

Phainon grins, delighted. “No need to sound so confused. There’s no emergency,” he calls to the sky. The smile on his face is nearly blinding. “Just keep the front door open for me, would you? I wouldn’t want to kick it down and ruin all your hard work.”

Keep the front door open…? *Oh.* That would explain the red sky.

Caelus grins. That’s so *sweet.* The thought of Phainon summoning Mydei like an RPG god nearly brings a tear to his eye.

Phainon turns to them, sheer happiness on his face. “Thank you, my friends,” he beams. “If all goes well, I will return to Okhema in no time.”

“Wait, we’re not coming with you?” Caelus says, puzzled.

Before he can ask more questions—because after all of his plans, what do you *mean* they’re not going to witness the dazzling finale—Dan Heng claps a hand over his mouth.

“You’re welcome,” Dan Heng tells Phainon, even as Caelus writhes in his arms like an unruly python. “Good luck, and safe travels, Phainon.”

He waits until Phainon is just a blue blob in the distance, before letting Caelus extract himself from his grip.

“We definitely could’ve gone with him,” Caelus complains. “I wanted front row seats. I even brought popcorn.”

Dan Heng shakes his head, looking contemplative.

“I think this, of all things, is something we shouldn’t meddle in,” he says softly.

Seven days later, the masses report of Phainon’s return. Word on the street is that he returned to Okhema whistling, flushed under the perpetual daylight of the Dawn Device, and with the distinct glow of a newly courted man.

Caelus asks him to visit their room anyway. He needs to confirm that last part for himself, before he explodes out of excitement.

“So? How was it?” he asks Phainon with bated breath. *If you two don’t have any juicy stories, I’m rioting,* he doesn’t say.

“Good,” Phainon replies. His voice turns dreamy. “Better than good. We have an arrangement, now.” Caelus notices that his cheeks are tinted pink. *Aww.* “We may not have much time left, but any time I can have with him is better than nothing.”

“I’m glad you figured that out,” Caelus says, happily. “I can’t believe I’m about to say this, but I’m going to miss watching you two dance around each other.”

Phainon snickers. “Really? I was under the impression that you hated it.”

Caelus shrugs, good-naturedly. He’s just thankful he can look back on it all with rose-tinted glasses in the first place.

“On that note, may I borrow your board?” Phainon asks suddenly.

“Sure,” Caelus says, and passes it over. “What for?”

Instead of answering, Phainon stares down at the whiteboard, and uncaps the pen. His tongue sticks out of his mouth as he concentrates, and he deliberates for a minute before decisively penning a string of words that Caelus has to crane his neck to see.

~~*CAELUS’ AND DAN HENG’S INFALLIBLE 10 STEP PLAN TO STOP BEING A THIRD WHEEL GET PHAINON AND MYDEI TOGETHER BEFORE A) CAELUS GOES CRAZY B) THEY DIE C) BOTH??? WHY NOT THIS LIFE??????*~~

PHAINON’S FOOLPROOF GUIDE TO (DAN HENG) WINNING THE HEART OF YOUR MOST DEARLY BELOVED (CAELUS)

Current Tropes:

1. “Yaoi?” (Definition to be checked!!! :D)

“I figured I should repay the favour,” Phainon says brightly. He tilts the board towards Dan Heng, just out of Caelus’ line of sight.

Dan Heng looks at it. His face goes ashen. “Absolutely not.”

For some reason, he climbs to his feet and tries to leave the room entirely. Phainon lurches forward, and manages to catch the tail of his ornaments.

“Wait! I have a track record in these things, so we can get you results in no time! Also, although Mydei pretends that he has no interest in these things, deep down he actually does, so this really is something worthwhile—”

Caelus distinctly feels like he’s missed something. “Hey, what’s on the board?” he demands. He leans over, and swipes for his whiteboard. “Hello? Hellooooo? Guys? Is there another couple I should be concerned about—?”

“Please don’t read that,” Dan Heng says, desperately.

“You can’t stop me, it’s *my whiteboard,”* Caelus argues back. He tugs the whiteboard out of a laughing Phainon’s hands, and turns it over—

—before watching as a jetstream of water slashes it into two clean pieces.

Caelus crosses his arms. “Seriously?”

With great shame, Dan Heng retracts his giant tail from where it’s curling around Caelus’ wrist. He lifts his hands to cover his horns, but it’s a futile effort.

“What the fuck,” says Phainon, flabbergasted. He jumps to his feet, mouth hanging wide open. His eyes look like they’re bugging out of his skull. “Wait. What—Dan Heng, are you —”

Dan Heng puts his face in his hands, and groans. Caelus, for his part, manages to stay silent for all of ten seconds, before he bursts into laughter.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

hello! i have been wanting to write a spiritual sequel to this fic for a while, and this had actually been in the works since i posted the first chapter last year. however, life got very very busy for me, and as a result... i am actually still on 3.1/2 LOL. therefore there may be lore inaccuracies (which i am sorry for!) for which i was debating even posting this, but in the end i decided to because i thought that it might be enjoyable for someone out there.

this was also heavily inspired by this comment. the idea of dan heng somehow being an unwilling homewrecker made me laugh so bad, so thank you so much!

to note, this chapter is heavily dancae focused. for those who only want to see what mydei and phainon were getting up to, here it is

finally, any inaccuracies are entirely my own. i hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It is a typical sunny day in the Marmoreal Diner when Phainon corners Caelus. What is not so typical (or maybe it is, because Caelus has done a lot of strange things in the Diner) is that Phainon finds Caelus as he's wailing into his cup, while the other customers look on awkwardly.

"May I sit here?" Phainon asks him. Caelus nods, miserable, and watches as Phainon takes the seat across from him.

Phainon makes a sympathetic face. "What happened? Are you alright?"

Caelus shows him his phone screen. "My favourite character just *died,"* he bawls.

"I'm sorry to hear that," Phainon says. He reaches out, and pats Caelus on the shoulder.

Caelus takes the opportunity to bawl louder. The customer on their right visibly flinches.

"I spent *hours* grinding for his levels," Caelus wails. He swipes a hand across his eyes, and dries his tears. "He was beautiful to me."

Phainon, still solemn, blinks at him. *Do they even have games on their teleslates in Amphoreus,* Caelus despairs. If not, the citizens are missing out, but it would explain why Phainon's looking at him like he's grown a second head. As if crying about a dead character was *stupid.*

Caelus opens his mouth to ask exactly that, but Phainon is already moving on.

“Speaking of beautiful men,” Phainon says smoothly, before winking—*read the room,* Caelus thinks indignantly, *my favourite character just DIED!!!*— “I actually came here to ask you a few questions, if you’d be happy to answer them.” He pauses, and scrutinises Caelus. He’s probably looking at the tear tracks still fresh on his cheeks. “Of course, if now isn’t a good time, I can always return later.”

Caelus waves him off. “It’s fine,” he sniffs. Then, he pauses. “Wait. What do you mean by ‘beautiful men’?”

Phainon laughs. “Exactly that. You see, I wanted to ask you about Dan Heng.” He leans forward in his chair, and interlocks his fingers. The motion makes him look like some sort of —mafia boss. “You mentioned that he had a previous lover?”

The gears going ballistic in Caelus’ head grind to a halt. He blanks.

Had he mentioned that?

Phainon gives him an encouraging nod. Caelus glances down at the table, and nearly startles when he realises that Phainon’s whipped out a golden pen. Said pen is poised over a pad of paper, evidently ready to scribble.

He looks up. The twinkle in Phainon’s eye is kind of scary.

“I think Dan Heng’s been married before,” Caelus offers slowly, “but it—” *wasn’t really him? It was his past incarnation who just so happened to look like him?* He has no idea how to explain Dan Heng’s long, confusing history.

Whatever. He can simplify it. Probably.

“His husband died,” Caelus decides. “And then Dan Heng died,” *sorry, Dan Heng, but Phainon won’t get it otherwise*, “but then he came back, and his husband also came back, and now that husband is his ex and used to spend his time hunting Dan Heng down. Dan Heng killed him once or twice, but it never works because he’s basically immortal. Like Mydei, but less polite and more murderous.”

The sound of furious scribbling pauses. Caelus chances a glance at Phainon, only to find him staring back at Caelus—politely, because it’s Phainon, but also like he’s actually grown a second head this time.

Caelus winces. “... It’s difficult to explain?”

“I… see.” Phainon clearly does not see, but thankfully, he doesn’t press. And as amazingly perceptive as Caelus is, he really has no clue how to explain Vidyadharan rebirth. “And is this ex-husband… out of the picture?”

Caelus scratches his nose. “Er,” he says intelligently, thinking back to the last time they saw Blade. “We do see him from time to time? He doesn’t really talk to us, though. I tried texting him once and he left me on read.”

“He doesn’t pursue Dan Heng?” Phainon presses, oddly intent. “They aren’t together?”

“He’s pretty obsessive…” Caelus frowns. “But he was calmer the last time I saw him. We try to keep them apart when we can. I don’t think they’re together.” *Unless Dan Heng has been keeping a secret of epic proportions from everyone, that is.*

At that, Phainon relaxes. He seems pleased. “Perfect! Are there any other contenders I should know about?”

“Contenders?” Like other lovers? Caelus furrows his brow. For some reason, he feels a sense of unease pool in his gut, like some sort of parasite wiggling about. “Well, there is this… general, and potentially a space cowboy, but to be honest, I think they’re just friends.”

“I see,” Phainon hums. He taps the pen against his bottom lip, looking very considerate and thoughtful. Caelus innocently peers over to look at his paper, but Phainon swiftly hides it from view, cheerful smile still on his face. *Damn.*

“That’s helpful,” Phainon continues. “Would you be able to tell me a little more about this general?”

“Sure,” says Caelus. He’s always up for glazing Jing Yuan, even if he has no idea why Phainon is asking.

Caelus shifts in his seat, and thinks. “Er—there’s a lot to say about him. He’s very strong. He can hold an eight-tonne guandao in one hand.” Caelus holds up his hands, and spreads them apart in an approximate estimate of Starfall Reverie’s size. “He loves animals, and he’s very gentle with them. I heard that he used to have a pet lion.”

“A pet lion? Interesting,” mutters Phainon, scribbling furiously even as he doesn’t break eye contact. The way those baby blue eyes bore into Caelus is kind of uncanny. “Anything else?”

Caelus shrugs helplessly. “Uh… Birds flock to him? As well as all the women. And the men.” He wracks his brain. “I heard he’s been the Most Eligible Bachelor on the Luofu for nearly 700 years running. And all his photocards keep selling out.”

Phainon’s pen has not left the paper in the entire time Caelus has spoken. It’s honestly impressive. Caelus thinks Phainon would make a great journalist, if he wasn’t a Deliverer.

Partly to give himself some reprieve, Caelus takes out his phone and navigates to his photo gallery. He tilts his screen in Phainon’s direction.

It’s a photo of Jing Yuan, napping serenely, with a finch nestled in his hair. Phainon gives it a passing glance, expression unchanging.

“Hmm,” is all he has to say.

Caelus blinks. Usually that picture gets a blush, even by decidedly unsingle men. Maybe Phainon is simply too loyal, in which case, good for him for escaping the allure of the esteemed General, he who unwittingly tempts even the most monogamous of men (not on purpose, is Caelus’ understanding, but the point still stands).

Phainon presses on. “And is this general—in a relationship?”

Caelus stretches his legs. He thinks to himself: can he describe the historical love triangle-slash-threesome that Jing Yuan had going on with his old friends? And comes to the conclusion that *no, he probably can’t.*

“Not that I know of?” Caelus answers instead. “Everyone wants him, but he’s kind of a… single father, with the aura of… a mourning widow?”

Phainon gives him a look of confusion. *Come on,* Caelus wants to wail, *you’d agree with me if you saw him!*

“A mourning widow full of whimsy,” is the descriptor that Caelus finally decides on. “Which I think actually adds to his appeal.” He thinks back to the numerous photocards that he’s seen, and the way the General had been portrayed on them. Enduring, gentle and world-weary—a perfect combination of traits that cater to literally everyone. “You could describe him as a MILF, I guess?”

Phainon cocks his head. “A MILF?”

In Caelus’ mind, an image of Dan Heng looming over him threateningly crystallises frighteningly fast.

“It’s nothing,” Caelus says hastily.

Thankfully, Phainon chooses to let it go. He stares at his paper and mutters under his breath instead, looking dissatisfied. “And what about this… ‘cow boy’?”

“He’s… eccentric,” Caelus answers, after some deliberation. “But funny. He’s a good guy, even if he likes to jump the gun a lot. Literally.”

“Hmm,” Phainon says. He scribbles harder, face scrunched up into an expression of absolute concentration. Caelus tries to read his writing upside down again, until he realises that Phainon is scrawling so quickly that his notes are all illegible shorthand. “And you’re sure there’s no one else?”

“Not that I know of,” Caelus says, slowly. The unease in his gut tugs again, insistent. “Why do you want to know all this?”

“Don’t worry about it,” Phainon says gravely. He tucks his papers away, looking immensely pleased with himself. Confused, Caelus can only watch on as Phainon rises to his feet.

“One last thing,” Phainon says brightly. “Do you have a spare board lying around?”

“A whiteboard? No,” Caelus answers, shaking his head. “Dan Heng broke my only one.”

“Worth a try,” Phainon smiles at him. He gives Caelus a jaunty wave. “I’ll see you later, my friend.”

With that, he's out—a flash of gold, white and royal blue hurrying around the corner with a skip in his step. Caelus stares after him, wondering just what the hell he had been subjected to.

Most of Phainon's words had sounded vaguely… ominous. Caelus prides himself on knowing Dan Heng's juicy secrets so that he can pretend to use them as leverage over other people, but they're all random useless Dan Heng facts (see example: inside behind-the-scenes anecdotes about his misshapen knitting attempts) rather than anything actually important. He doesn't actually know about Dan Heng's romantic past, other than the details the man has explicitly told him—which is basically nothing.

Phainon had been weirdly interested in Dan Heng's dating history. And Caelus, for the life of him, can't think of a reason *why.* Apart from the obvious conclusion.

Which isn't actually that obvious, because—well.

Caelus frowns. He swipes back to his game, and unpauses the screen. His favourite character is still lying in the rainy field, where he's just been pelted with bullets, and his friend is crying over him. Caelus' eyes twitch, and so does his gut.

His favourite character gives his sword and legacy to his friend, and says some touching parting words before he dies. His friend screams, bone-chilling, and then the credits roll, and Caelus, through his welling tears, tries not to think about his conversation with Phainon.

Caelus keeps thinking about his conversation with Phainon.

It just doesn't make sense. Why would Phainon suddenly ask him about Dan Heng's exes? To Caelus' knowledge, Phainon has never shown so much interest in Dan Heng before, so for him to suddenly raise so many questions is baffling.

After an hour of furious pondering, the only sensible conclusion Caelus comes up with is that Phainon could possibly want Dan Heng… carnally?

Is it because Dan Heng accidentally let slip some of his more draconian features, and Phainon was impressed? As much as Caelus hates to admit it, it kind of makes sense. After all, the first time that Caelus saw Dan Heng like that, his first thought had been something along the lines of '*please step on me please please please*'. It would be understandable if other people experienced the same emotion.

But the last time he checked, Phainon should be deeply in love with Mydei—not only because Caelus had quite literally risked his life trying to get the both of them together, but

also because there really is no other explanation. The other day he'd found Phainon wearing Mydei's earring, looking extraordinarily pleased with himself. Matching earrings are basically matching wedding rings in Caelus' book—as are the letters he keeps seeing Phainon send, and the longing glances he sees Phainon direct towards the general direction of Castrum Kremnos, with enough yearning to fill even the most sappiest romance books, etcetera etcetera.

The point is that Phainon is a very happily taken man. As a happily taken man, why would he enquire about other men? Is that something that men do in Amphoreus?

Unfortunately, Caelus doesn't get to think about it much, because for some reason, the door to his and Dan Heng's room is stuck.

"I can't believe that we're actually stuck in our own room," Caelus complains. He shoots off a quick SOS text to the Chrysos Heirs, and watches despairingly as no one responds.

"Hmm," says Dan Heng, staring at the opposite wall.

"I mean, you would think we'd have trust issues after getting drugged in here," Caelus rants. "Actually, I do have trust issues."

"Mm."

"Imagine they forgot about us here and we starved to death." Caelus flops into a chair. He dramatically pretends to die. "Goodbye, Astral Express. Goodbye, March's souvenirs."

"Mmm."

Caelus chances a quick glance at Dan Heng. He's still staring at the far wall, but the crease in his brow is much more pronounced than Caelus would like.

Caelus swings his legs over the chair, and leans forward.

"Dan Heng, are you okay?" he asks seriously. "Are you feeling sick?"

"I'm fine," Dan Heng says, far too quickly. "You shouldn't worry about me."

He can say that all he likes, but Caelus knows that look. Dan Heng is antsy, fingers twitching like he wants to fidget but he's just about stopping himself. It's the same way he looked the first time they visited the Luofu, back when he thought Caelus and March were busy getting skewered on the end of Blade's, well, blade.

"You look down," Caelus offers. "Want a hug?"

Dan Heng closes his eyes. When he speaks, he sounds pained. "No."

Caeus opens his mouth to pester him again, but gets interrupted by a thump from the door.

He whirls around. "Is someone there?" he calls hopefully. "Hello? We're stuck— can you try and open the door from your side?"

The other side of the door is silent, even when Caelus rattles the doorknob and tugs it so hard he nearly breaks the thing. After struggling for a minute, and the lack of any response, he gives up. It was worth a try.

“Huh. Must have been the wind,” Caelus mutters. He turns around, and gives Dan Heng his signature thousand-watt smile. “Don’t worry, Dan Heng—I’ll get us out of here, no matter what. In the meantime…” now, he plasters on his most pathetic, pleading face, “are you *sure* you don’t want a hug?”

Dan Heng sighs. The crease in his brow softens, and his expression slips to one of fond, familiar exasperation.

That’s more like it, thinks Caelus happily.

“I’m truly fine, Caelus,” Dan Heng says, with the infinite patience of a long-suffering man. He pauses. *“*Please don’t jump on me.”

Caelus pouts, relaxing out of his stance. “Worth a try,” he sighs. Then, he retrieves his bat from its resting place next to his bed, and faces the door. “Well, then. Looks like we only have one solution left, huh?”

“Caelus,” Dan Heng launches forward, alarmed, *“*no, *we’ve already been charged for property damage—”*

So Caelus may have forgotten that Aglaea could deliver him a look *that* severe. Whoops! His fault.

In the process of getting stuck in their room for a day and collecting a second charge for property damage shortly afterwards, Caelus almost forgets about the whole Dan Heng and

Phainon thing. Almost, until he happens to overhear (and definitely *not* eavesdrop on) a particular conversation later that day.

It's not the sound of Phainon whining that clues him in, but rather, the sound of Phainon whining at Dan Heng, which is something that Caelus never thought he would see.

Caelus ducks behind a convenient pillar.

"—it was the perfect opportunity!" Phainon's saying.

"It really wasn't," Dan Heng sighs. "The timing was terrible."

"You have to make your intentions known—"

Caelus frowns. Intentions? What intentions?

Dan Heng crosses his arms. Caelus can't make out his expression at this distance, but if he could hazard a guess, he would say that Dan Heng is probably looking exasperated again.

"Like you did?" Dan Heng asks.

The silence that follows is pointed.

"That was different!" Phainon protests. He sounds almost… embarrassed?

Dan Heng sighs again. "Thank you, Phainon, but I can't just…"

Caelus holds his breath and tries to focus on their voices, but the pair are already walking away. His mind races. What 'intentions' does Dan Heng have? Does he have—a crush? The thought makes Caelus' stomach twist, because the last time Dan Heng got into a relationship, his ex chased him across the entire universe.

Besides, he's made a pact with March about this. If Dan Heng has a crush, then Caelus will definitely have to investigate for the both of them, because March would never let him live it down if she heard that he'd done nothing for their friend's honour.

Caelus parks that troubling thought, and strains to listen to the last snatches of conversation before the pair disappear around the corner entirely.

"—spring this… out of nowhere," Dan Heng's saying. He sounds unhappy, now—almost frustrated.

Phainon earnestly lays a hand on Dan Heng's shoulder. "Don't worry," he tells Dan Heng, and Caelus fights the urge to shiver. "Leave it to me."

Phainon and Dan Heng were clearly discussing something important. *But about what,* Caelus thinks, more than a little disconcerted, *and why is Dan Heng speaking to Phainon about it, and not me?*

As it turns out, Phainon and Dan Heng keep discussing something important, because it seems that every time Caelus tries to catch Dan Heng, he's talking with Phainon.

Take today, for example. Phainon's talking to Dan Heng with so much excitement that he's practically sparkling. Dan Heng responds with what Caelus can only describe as a groan. The tips of his ears are *red.*

Caelus feels stung. Since when did they get so close?

He doesn't get time to ponder their relationship, because Phainon spots him easily. He elbows Dan Heng in the side, and points towards Caelus' direction. His eyes are gleaming.

Dan Heng looks over. His eyes are decidedly *not* gleaming. He looks more like a deer caught in headlights.

"Would you look at that? I'm late for a meeting," Phainon says, far too loudly. "I'll talk to you both later!"

With that, Phainon disappears—quite literally—in a flash. Caelus will never understand how he does that.

He turns to Dan Heng. "What was that about?" Caelus asks, lost. "And what are you wearing?"

Dan Heng sighs, before slowly turning around. "Lady Aglaea felt compelled to make us new outfits that… better suit Okhema's climate, as thanks for our aid to the Flamechase Journey," he says, stiffly. "She made you a set, too. I've left it in our room."

Caelus tries very hard not to stare.

Dan Heng's wearing a sleeveless chiton that drapes artfully around his shoulders and legs. The teal accents match the jade of his eyes. He looks beautiful.

Not that he doesn't always look beautiful. He just looks extra beautiful right now. Dreamy, even. Men would probably kill each other to see his ankles, and now look at him.

Despite his new fit, Dan Heng only scrunches in on himself, and looks away. The tips of his ears are still red, and his mouth is pursed unhappily.

Caelus frowns. It's not like Dan Heng to be self-conscious. Maybe he's cold? Or maybe the outfit shows too much skin? Dan Heng is usually more covered up, after all. His Imbibitor Lunae fit only really shows off his arms and that glorious back window, but Aglaea's design leaves much more on display.

… Is Dan Heng uncomfortable?

A crowd of people have gathered behind them, tittering away with hushed whispers. Caelus usually pays their gossip no mind, but this time he only feels irritated. He steps forward, shielding Dan Heng from view, and shrugs out of his jacket.

"You'll catch a cold," Caelus scolds. Carefully, he drapes his jacket around Dan Heng's shoulders, where goosebumps have already started studding his skin. "It's not like you to forget your jacket, at least. You should be more careful."

In the crowd, someone coughs. They sound almost incredulous.

Dan Heng sags with relief, and clutches the jacket around himself. He looks a bit ridiculous, but he definitely looks warmer. "You're right; I will. Thank you, Caelus," he says. Then, in a decidedly icier tone: "I should *never have worn this in the first place."*

Caelus blinks. That sounded like it was directed at someone. But the crowd, easily bored, has already dispersed, and when he looks over, Dan Heng only seems to be glaring at… a barrel.

Eh, whatever. As long as Dan Heng's feeling better, and no one's laughing at him, Caelus won't pay it too much attention.

"—didn't think you'd be one to give up!"

Caelus, who actually didn't mean to overhear this particular conversation, freezes in his tracks.

"Of course not, Hyacine, but don't you think there's an issue here if Mydei is having an easier job of this than I am? And he isn't even in the city!" he hears Phainon groan. "Do you think that Dan Heng…"

Hyacine and Phainon's voices trail off. Distantly, Caelus realises that there is undeniably something happening between Phainon and Dan Heng, that he can't pass off as a coincidence

now that even Hyacine is in on it.

Well! All this means is that he just has to snoop around and find out what the deal is. It shouldn't be too difficult a job for Caelus, Mr Ace Detective. His sleuthing skills are the best in the universe, and once he's on a case, he never gives up.

Caelus gives up.

"Dan Heng!" he shouts, slamming their door open. "Where are you? I need answers from you right… now…"

Inside the room, Dan Heng yelps—honest to Aeons *yelps*—and then whirls around, hands hidden behind his back.

"Caelus. Hello," Dan Heng says, stiff as a board. "You're back rather early."

Caelus squints at Dan Heng, the same way he squints at March when she gets her hands on the cookie jar. Dan Heng only shuffles backwards in response, looking carefully neutral.

"Is that…"

"It's nothing," Dan Heng cuts him off, far too smoothly.

Caelus gasps, scandalised. "You're hiding *porn?"*

At that, Dan Heng goes scarlet. "What—*no—"*

"Or what—adult literature? Doujinshi?" Caelus presses. He grins, enjoying the familiar glee that comes with teasing Dan Heng. "It's a doujinshi, isn't it? Dan Heng, you sly dog, did you sneak this onto the car with you—?"

Dan Heng's face now looks hot enough to power several suns. Honestly, Caelus is worried that he'll start to turn purple if he keeps going.

"It's not a doujinshi—" Dan Heng hisses, practically steaming from his ears, "or—*porn,* or any other idea you've conjured in your mind—"

"Well, you're hiding it like your life depends on it, so what else could it be apart from some —" Caelus consults his brain, and thinks of something that could make his dear friend pass

out, "—limited edition Jing Yuan playboy-esque boudoir bust-related—*ow ow ow* okay OKAY you can stop—!"

Dan Heng stops hitting him over the head. His red cheeks are adorable. "Please never refer to the General like that ever again."

"You can't deny it," Caelus points out reasonably. "Anyway, there's no need to be ashamed. I don't think anyone in Amphoreus even knows what a doujinshi is."

Dan Heng huffs. "Again, that's not what it is," he says pointedly, but looking less like a tomato and more like a Dan Heng, which Caelus supposes is a good thing. "But if you won't be convinced… fine. Here."

With what seems like great reluctance (and is that a whispered plea for mercy that Caelus hears?), Dan Heng hands Caelus the object he was hiding behind his back earlier, which happens to be… a piece of paper.

"What is it?" Caelus asks.

"I received a letter," Dan Heng says. His tone is evasive.

Caelus peers down at the paper, hoping to get a sneak peek. Dan Heng, the party pooper, tilts the letter away from him, but he's not quick enough to hide the sender's name.

Caelus' jaw drops, because that name is the last person he'd expect to be writing to Dan Heng.

"Happy now?" Dan Heng sighs, looking tired beyond his years.

"You're writing to Mydei?" Caelus gapes. *"Mydei?"*

He knew that Mydei and Phainon had been communicating, but he assumed that was because they were a thing, now. He didn't think Mydei would even have the time to write to anyone other than his new boyfriend. He also didn't think Mydei and Dan Heng had that much in common that they'd be writing to each other like—*penpals,* or something.

Dan Heng shrugs. He looks very calm about this, Caelus notes, with some level of dull panic. "I only wanted to ask him a few questions. He's just offering some advice."

For some reason, his response just makes Caelus feel slightly ugly. "You've never written to *me* before," he accuses.

At that, Dan Heng just presses a finger to his temple, looking like he's nursing a headache. "That's because we've always been together."

That's true, and it's a comforting thought.

Still. Why would Mydei and Dan Heng write to each other while Mydei's away fighting a one-man war?

Caelus is really having a problem, recently, regarding the amount of unwanted conversations he's stumbling into. Especially when the number of unwanted conversations outnumbers the number of conversations he actually wants to eavesdrop on.

"He totally liked seeing you like that," he hears Phainon tease, a few alleys away.

"I felt like a fool," comes the disgruntled response.

From *Dan Heng.*

The words take a moment to register, but when they do, Caelus realises that he's about two seconds away from passing out in the middle of the street.

Is Dan Heng sending pictures of himself? To Mydei? Pictures that Mydei *liked?*

And Phainon *knows about it?*

"We could put you in the baths?" Phainon muses, oblivious to Caelus nearly keeling over behind them.

"Please. No more of that," Dan Heng mutters tiredly. "I don't think it would be very effective. I'd also like to preserve my own dignity, if at all possible."

Caelus' legs go slack with shock, and nearly give out.

Is Dan Heng sending NUDES? Dan Heng?? *Dan Heng???*

For some reason, Phainon only sounds *crestfallen.* "I see you really are taking Mydei's advice. When did he write to you last? He's been ignoring me—probably because of our competition—and please don't tell him this but I can't believe that he's winning when he's not even present—"

ARE YOU AND MYDEI NOT TOGETHER??? Caelus wants to scream. *WHAT THE HELL HAPPENED IN THE SPACE OF ONE WEEK???*

He misses the rest of the conversation and honestly most of everything else after that, because Dan Heng and Phainon's voices get closer, and thus Caelus is forced to run back to his room, feeling confused and also strangely like some sort of heartbroken maiden.

So apparently Dan Heng is with Mydei… with Phainon's permission? Did Phainon and Mydei break up? There's no way they'd break up—yet Caelus can't think of any other alternative to describe what he'd just witnessed.

The prospect leaves a sour taste in Caelus' mouth, and he gets the sudden urge to find the nearest wall and bash his head against it.

Caelus' mood is terrible enough that even the prospect of gathering intel doesn't thrill him the way it used to. He spends the next few days moping around Okhema and halfheartedly fulfilling people's requests. Judging by the worried glances the citizens are giving him, he probably looks like some sort of listless ghost, dragging his feet everywhere and rattling his metaphorical chains in agony and despair.

Caelus can't find it within himself to care anymore. No one presses the issue, which is fine by him. Let him mope it out of his system. He'll be back to normal in a few days.

No one presses apart from Dan Heng, that is, because he's Dan Heng.

"What happened to your head?" Dan Heng asks Caelus, cornering him in their room. His arms are crossed, and his frown is severe. He's also unhelpfully positioned right in front of their door, so Caelus can't even make a run for it—unless he tries to take a swan dive out of the window (which is looking incredibly tempting right now, even if Dan Heng would have a heart attack in the process).

"Don't worry about it," Caelus grunts instead.

He sounds petulant even to his own ears, and it makes Dan Heng only scrutinise him harder. Caelus shrinks away, feeling like a bug under a microscope.

Finally, Dan Heng sighs, and uncrosses his arms.

"Let's go for a meal," he suggests. "We haven't eaten together in a while."

His tone is so gentle that it kind of wants to make Caelus cry. He nods, and follows Dan Heng out of their chambers.

They end up at a restaurant in one of the back alleys of the city. Caelus hasn't dined here before, but the place smells divine. The meat skewers sizzling on the counter nearly make Caelus' mouth water, and he stares after them longingly.

"Two of the skewers, please," Dan Heng tells the vendor smoothly.

His voice jolts Caelus out of his meat-induced reverie. "I was going to order for us," he says, crestfallen.

Dan Heng raises a brow. "Would you have chosen differently?"

"... no."

"Then my point stands." *You have to be faster than that,* Dan Heng's eyes say, glinting mischievously.

Caelus tries very hard not to pout at him, but then their food arrives, and he stops thinking about the events of the past few days.

He tears into his skewers. They're divine; the meat is succulent and the vegetables are crisp. He nearly moans out loud, but just about restrains himself, because Dan Heng was kind enough to bring him here, and embarrassing him in return—while ordinarily would have been the funniest thing ever—is probably not the best way to pay him back.

Dan Heng also seems to be enjoying the meal. He's eating at a much slower pace than Caelus, but he looks noticeably more relaxed. Happier, too.

Caelus swallows, his throat suddenly dry. He puts down his clean skewer.

Dan Heng looks satisfied enough that now would be a great time to ask him about Phainon and Mydei. Somehow, the thought of doing so makes Caelus' side ache with quiet loneliness.

Under the table, Dan Heng gently nudges the side of Caelus' foot with his own. "Credit for your thoughts?"

Caelus automatically nudges him back, but deliberately avoids his gaze. Depending on how this conversation goes, he'll either need to take out his tissues, or his baseball bat. He doesn't particularly want to use either.

"What?" he mumbles instead. "You know me. I'm not thinking about anything."

Dan Heng also lays down his skewer. It's half-finished, Caelus notes distantly.

"You seem… preoccupied," Dan Heng says slowly. "Is everything all right?"

Caelus sighs. Well, Dan Heng's given him an opportunity. It would be rude not to take it, after all.

“Listen. About you and Mydei …”

Predictably, Dan Heng tenses. “What about him?”

Caelus takes a deep breath. “Are you sure there’s nothing going on between you two?” he asks, trying not to sound too miserable.

Dan Heng gives him a wary look. “We only write,” he says, carefully, “Occasionally, and about nothing in particular.”

“You told me you needed ‘advice’. That’s not nothing,” Caelus presses.

Dan Heng stays silent, and Caelus has to fight the urge to twiddle his fingers or fidget or even crack another ill-timed joke, just to dispel the awkward air that’s suddenly grown between them like a persistent mold.

“Come onnnn,” Caelus chuckles awkwardly. Despite his best efforts, it comes out sounding incredibly forced. He winces. “You can tell me. We’re bros, aren’t we?”

For some reason, Dan Heng looks pained. Caelus also … actually feels pained after saying that, so he moves swiftly on.

“What about Phainon, then?” he asks instead.

At that, Dan Heng looks away and avoids Caelus’ gaze entirely. “Phainon and I… are simply engaging in a debate that has gone on for far longer than it should. I promise it’s not anything more than what it seems.”

“A debate?” Caelus wrinkles his nose. That’s not what he expected. “About what?”

“I’d rather not say,” Dan Heng says evasively.

Caelus valiantly tries not to feel hurt at that admission. He fails miserably.

“... Do you want me to talk to him?” Caelus hedges awkwardly.

At that, Dan Heng’s gaze snaps back to Caelus in an instant. His eyes are wide.

“No!” Dan Heng says, far too quickly. “No. It’s okay, truly.”

Caelus stares at him. Something’s off, because Dan Heng’s cheeks are pink, and they’re steadily growing pinker. So pink they could almost be mistaken for…

Oh, Caelus thinks wryly. *That’s what it is.*

He does need to get out the baseball bat after all—but not for Mydei.

Honestly, this should be a happy occasion. After all, even after his heartbreak on the Luofu, Dan Heng finally has a crush again. What a wonderful, beautiful thing.

Caelus tries to ignore the way his stomach falls at the prospect.

“Okay. I get it,” Caelus says, as brightly as he can manage. He barely manages to keep his voice from cracking.

Dan Heng visibly relaxes. He looks hopeful. “You do?”

“Yeah, of course,” Caelus says, braving a smile. He fiddles with the rim of his cup. “I just want you to be happy.”

At that, Dan Heng’s face softens. He reaches out, and pats the back of Caelus’ hand. His fingers are unfairly soft. “That’s sweet of you. But you don’t have to worry about me.”

But Caelus *does* have to worry. Dan Heng might be happy with his crush, but Caelus has to make sure that Dan Heng stays happy for the foreseeable future and beyond. He and March had promised that they would look out for him, after all, and since she’s down for the count, it’s up to Caelus to take up the mantle.

For all intents and purposes, Phainon is a taken man. But Caelus trusts his own memory; the conversations he’d overheard between Dan Heng and Phainon were definitely not *just friendly.* Is Phainon leading Dan Heng on? He has to know.

Phainon wouldn’t. He’s gentlemanly. And he loves Mydei, *extremely* non-platonically. So clearly the best case scenario here is that Phainon will very quickly (and gently) turn Dan Heng down, and then everyone can move on with their lives. Dan Heng might mope for a bit, but he should return to his usual self soon enough. At least, Caelus hopes so, because he has actually never seen Dan Heng in love before, so has no idea what it would look like. (He still thinks Dan Heng had something going on with Blade, but Dan Heng starts valiantly pretending he has hearing problems every time Caelus asks so what does he know).

Anyway. Given Phainon’s current affections for Mydei, Caelus figures that Dan Heng with a crush on Phainon can only mean a Dan Heng with his heart crushed. Which is fine—okay not fine, but *salvageable* —if Phainon lets him down gently.

If Phainon ever broke Dan Heng’s heart, Caelus would have to kill Phainon, and he doesn’t want that.

But at the same time, Caelus can’t deny that Dan Heng looks happy. Really happy. His cheeks are still as pink as a rose, but his frown lines look far less pronounced. His smile could probably stop a war right now. Or launch a thousand warships.

Could Phainon really look him in the eye and turn him down? Caelus probably couldn’t, and that’s saying something.

But the alternative is for Phainon to string Dan Heng along and never resolve anything between them, which Dan Heng would probably hate more.

Caelus decides that he won’t bring the issue up to Dan Heng now. Or ever, preferably. He’ll just sort it out himself.

That, however, is a problem for Future Caelus. Current Caelus decides to make the most of his dinner with his very good and very deserving friend, and finally changes the subject.

He flops dramatically against the table. “Did you know that Aglaea’s Garmentmakers apparently have a vendetta against me?”

“I didn’t,” Dan Heng hums. He leans forward, looking relieved at the change of topic, and pats the top of Caelus’ head. “Why do you think so?”

“Well…”

Future Caelus hates Past Caelus with a passion. Here he is, awake at an ungodly hour because he can’t stop thinking about Dan Heng’s doomed love life.

He still can’t believe that he was so wrong about Mydei. In one way, it works out better for everyone involved, because now all he potentially has to do is take his bat to Phainon. This still isn’t easy by any means of the word because Caelus has seen Phainon suplex beings twice his size, but it’s better than having to take his bat to *Mydei*.

Caelus doesn’t even know how he’d trek to Castrum Kremnos, let alone how he’d go and try to deliver a shovel talk to one of the most intimidating men he’s ever met. Mydei probably wouldn’t even move. He’d probably just cross his arms, look down at Caelus imposingly and raise an eyebrow in challenge, or something.

There’s also the black tide to think about, too. Mydei wouldn’t even have the time to listen to his shovel talk.

“Arghghhghghghghhhh,” Caelus whines.

“Go to sleep,” Dan Heng mumbles into his pillow.

Caelus cranes his neck and looks over to his companion. Dan Heng’s breathing is even, and his expression is unguarded. He looks completely at peace, and not at all like he dropped the world’s biggest bombshell on Caelus’ head yesterday.

“What am I going to do with you,” Caelus tells him despairingly.

Dan Heng’s response is to snore at him. Caelus waves a hand in front of his nose, and he doesn’t respond. Yep—he’s knocked out.

Hmm. Dan Heng is asleep, and one of his letters to Mydei is folded on the table next to him. If Caelus is careful enough, he can probably reach over Dan Heng's sleeping form and swipe it.

No. He can't be so nosy. Also, Dan Heng would realise what he's done *immediately.* There'd be no saving himself from the disappointment afterwards.

Caelus gives the letter one last longing glance, before rolling over and burrowing under his blankets.

Who knows. Maybe he won't even have to get out the bat. Maybe Dan Heng will get over his crush by himself, since he's an honourable man, and Phainon and Mydei's relationship will continue to blossom. That way, Caelus can whip out the tissues instead, and his bat can stay unused.

It would suck for Dan Heng, and would be really awkward if Phainon or Mydei ever found out, but hey, at least everyone's friendships would remain intact.

Or maybe Phainon's already done the opposite of letting Dan Heng down, and Dan Heng and Phainon are conducting a—secret relationship, instead. And Mydei's just sending his approval in his letters. And Caelus has no idea about any of this, because Dan Heng's too embarrassed to tell him.

No. Phainon and Mydei surely haven't broken up. Their love story was the stuff of ages. Everyone in the city was rooting for them. They even made Caelus the third wheel of this planet.

But then again, Caelus remembers the way one disgruntled woman in Penacony complained to him about how long-distance relationships never worked out… and if Dan Heng really has met the love of his life here, then who is Caelus to stop him?

With that delightful thought in mind, Caelus resentfully drifts off to sleep.

Caelus lied. He needs his bat immediately.

Phainon is growing tenser with each day that passes. His smile doesn't quite reach his eyes anymore, and Caelus has no idea what happened to make him so anxious. The only information he gets are snippets of conversation, none of which are directed towards him.

"Have you heard from Mydei?" Caelus overhears Phainon ask Dan Heng. He sounds strained. "I know he's been writing to you—"

“—I’m sorry,” Dan Heng says, sounding truly apologetic.

“—just that, I haven’t heard from him in a while—”

Phainon sounds wretched. Caelus has never heard him this close to falling apart before—

—which is when he realises—

Oh. Phainon and Mydei are definitely still *together.* And there’s no way that Phainon is leading Dan Heng on.

But that doesn’t make sense, because Caelus saw Dan Heng with another letter yesterday, which surely Dan Heng would’ve brought up by now, knowing that Phainon is worried out of his mind? Unless—

Caelus stops dead in his tracks. Unless…

He thinks back. Counts in his head the number of letters he’d seen Dan Heng receive, and the length of time between each. He compares them against the number of times he’d caught Phainon and Dan Heng having their ‘discussions’—or were they even discussions? Had Phainon been asking Dan Heng about Mydei, instead?

It doesn’t make sense. Mydei would never—*cheat,* he’s too respectable and honest but—what if the black tide has—Caelus has no idea. Side effects that cause infidelity? No—even in the black tide Mydei would stay faithful. He’d say something like *“I may die but my feelings will never die”* blah blah blah.

Caelus frowns. It doesn’t make sense.

When Phainon starts looking like he’s close to fraying apart at the seams, Caelus decides to take matters into his own hands. He helped undoom this yaoi—there’s no way he’s seeing it get doomed again.

He marches outside.

“Mydei,” Caelus hisses to the sky. “Hey, Mydei—you aren’t being accidentally rizzed up by Dan Heng too, are you? I know he’s alluring and sexy and hot but you have to resist it! He has too many victims! Trust me, you have to ignore him!”

No response. It seems that the boyfriend privileges don't extend to him. Defeated, Caelus trudges back to his room.

It must be accidental. That was how Dan Heng picked up Boothill, too. There's no way Dan Heng could have picked up Mydei on purpose.

Caelus feels like tearing his hair out. He doesn't want Dan Heng to pick up *anyone.* What the hell do you call that? Seriously, why does he want to swing a bat at anyone approaching Dan Heng with nefarious intentions? Is Dan Heng just that—easy to protect?

He's the *Express Guard.* He can take care of himself perfectly well. But Caelus' mind refuses to compute.

Is Dan Heng pursuing Mydei, or is he pursuing Phainon? Or are either of them pursuing him? Is Dan Heng the problem? Why does it feel like there's equal evidence for both scenarios?

Caelus freezes.

Oh shit, he thinks, with startling clarity.

Are Mydei and Phainon fighting over Dan Heng? Or are they all… a throuple?

Surely not.

Surely not???

Phainon disappears from Okhema. Dan Heng holes himself up in his room. Caelus, for his part, panics.

Is it simply Dan Heng's destiny to become entangled in doomed threesomes? It would be fine (no it would not) if they were all in a happy throuple. But Caelus swears he saw Phainon near

tears before he left, and found Dan Heng with his head in his hands right after. They didn't look happy at all.

So this is either some doomed yaoi to doomed polyamory yaoi pipeline (polyaoi?) or it's some sort of doomed love triangle, and Caelus can't figure out what's worse, and he wishes, above everything, that Dan Heng would trust him enough to tell him.

Therefore, he thinks it makes sense for him to be a bit irrational after running around in circles trying to get to the bottom of everything. So what comes next is—fine, he admits that it's wrong, but he spent so long trying to get Mydei and Phainon together, and Dan Heng was actually helping him by the end of it, and even if Dan Heng, Phainon and Mydei are actually a thing then Caelus would get over it and be happy for them but clearly none of them are happy, so what the hell is going on?

Tribbie only laughs at him when he tries to ask. Caelus is left with no one to turn to, and Dan Heng's destroyed his whiteboard, so he only really has one option left.

He yanks Dan Heng behind a wall.

"DAN HENG. I CAN'T BELIEVE YOU."

"Caelus?" Dan Heng hisses, alarmed. "What's going on—"

"DOES THE SANCTITY OF MARRIAGE MEAN NOTHING TO YOU ANYMORE," Caelus keeps bellowing. "YOU CAN'T JUST COME TO EVERY PLANET AND EXPECT A NEW HUSBAND—LET ALONE TWO—LIKE SOME SORT OF—CURIO DISPENSER FOR WIDOWERS."

Dan Heng's face goes through a peculiar series of expressions: shock, confusion, anger—and then he just looks embarrassed.

"Can you just—" Dan Heng puts his head in his hands. "Please stop shouting."

Caelus thinks of Phainon and Dan Heng, or Mydei and Dan Heng, or maybe Phainon, Mydei and Dan Heng, and wonders whether maybe he'll turn his back on them one day and they'll be having a threesome without telling him. Objectively, there's nothing wrong with that, but it also kind of makes Caelus want to set Amphoreus on fire, or more specifically set Phainon and Mydei on fire, because he would never do that to Dan Heng, but at the same time Caelus quite literally lost hair over getting Phainon and Mydei together, and honestly they're probably fireproof anyway, because one of them is literally a demigod, and the other one is

the human equivalent of a tank and missile rolled in one, so he'd have to try something else, but then Tribbie would be sad, and—he may be doomposting, here, but can you blame him?

"I EXPECTED BETTER FROM YOU," Caelus howls. "AFTER I WORKED SO HARD TO GET THEM TOGETHER—"

Dan Heng doesn't speak to him after that. Tribbie keeps looking between them with worried glances, but gives them a wide berth.

Caelus hates the silence, but he doesn't want to back down. He's no closer to finding out anything. And if Dan Heng doesn't want to tell him, then he's not going to beg.

Eventually, he decides to take up one of the citizens' requests, just to clear his mind. He doesn't take Dan Heng with him. It's a simple request, anyway—one of the shopkeepers is just asking him to get rid of some Titankin for them, which shouldn't be too much trouble.

Until he realises that the shopkeeper severely underestimated just how many Titankin were camping out in this patch of the road, and that Caelus was so desperate to get out of the city that he forgot to pack anything that could heal him. Soon enough, Caelus is laid out flat on his back, and a Titankin is looming over him. It's quite possibly the shittiest way to die, and in his last moments, Caelus curses himself for being so stupid.

Somewhere in the distance, a voice calls his name. Caelus can't pinpoint whether it's real, or a hallucination. The blood loss kind of makes it difficult to tell.

He promptly passes out.

Miraculously, Caelus wakes up.

"Hey," he coughs, weakly. His eyelids are stuck shut together, so he has to grope around until his hand hits something solid. "Why's it so… wet…"

“Caelus!” a voice shouts, far too loud and panicked to be comfortable.

Caelus groans. His ears are ringing, and he feels like he got run over like one of Penacony’s insane drivers. “Not so loud…”

The stickiness in his eyes slowly subsides. He cracks his eyes open, and watches blearily as the figure hovering above him swims into view.

“How do you feel?” Dan Heng asks.

“Like shit,” Caelus moans. He tries to sit up, but his head feels like someone dunked it in molasses and left it there to rot. He ends up flopping ungracefully back into Dan Heng’s arms. “... What happened?”

Dan Heng shifts so that Caelus isn’t half collapsed on the floor, and manoeuvres him so that he’s snug against Dan Heng’s chest.

“You were caught in an ambush,” Dan Heng tells him. His voice is tight. “What were you thinking?”

Caelus blinks. Why is Dan Heng hissing at him? Silly lizard.

“I was *thinking,”* he manages slowly, because words are suddenly difficult right now, “that I could help.”

“And how did that turn out?”

Caelus blinks at him incredulously. Dan Heng only glares back.

“Are you—mad at me?”

“What do you think,” Dan Heng seethes. Caelus nearly recoils; he’s never seen Dan Heng look this intense before. His gaze looks like it could burn through glass. “Why were you out here alone?”

“Why wouldn’t I be? Someone asked me to help them, so I did,” Caelus points out. “Besides, you’re literally cuddling me. And it’s raining. You’re making it *rain.”*

“That’s besides the point!” Dan Heng erupts, still cuddling him.

“And I’m—stop it, I’m supposed to be mad at *you,”* Caelus says, outraged. He tries to shake out of Dan Heng’s grip, but Dan Heng, the cheater, only wraps his arms around him tighter. “You—you homewrecker!”

Silence. Dan Heng continues to stare at him, but his face slackens in surprise.

Caelus glares back, defiant. He hasn’t said anything *wrong.*

“Don’t worry. He hasn’t wrecked any homes—” Phainon pipes up from Caelus’ other side, and Caelus nearly scrambles out of Dan Heng’s arms because *since when did they have an*

audience? "—or any other structures, for that matter. To be honest, it's nice to have some rain in the city for once."

When the hell did Phainon get here? Caelus thinks woozily, before: *What the hell is he talking about?*

"... Did I say something wrong?" Phainion asks, after a moment of silence.

Right. They don't have homewreckers in Amphoreus. They probably have—harlots, or something. But Dan Heng the Harlot just doesn't have the same ring to it as Dan Heng the Homewrecker.

Dan Heng shakes himself out of his stupor. He rounds on Caelus again.

"What are you talking about?" he asks. And he has the audacity to look exasperated! Caelus bristles with indignation. *"Who* are you talking about?"

"You know exactly what I'm talking about," Caelus accuses. "I know you're like—the hottest man ever, and you're a total catch, but you can't just go around—" here, he lowers his voice, "—breaking up other couples!"

Phainon is giving them an odd look. Caelus ignores him, and struggles to get up. He gives Dan Heng a look of profound sadness.

"I didn't go through my ten step plan for nothing," Caelus says in a small voice. "And now look at what's happened. Mydei's in love with you."

Phainon inhales sharply. "Mydei's *what?*"

"And Phainon's in love with you too!"

This makes Phainon pause. "... I am?"

At last, the cat's out of the bag. Dully, Caelus realises that he can finally come clean with his deductions.

"You don't have to deny it," Caelus says miserably. "I overheard you both. I saw the letters, too. And I don't blame you either." Here, he turns to Phainon apologetically. "Dan Heng's just like that. He attracts everyone he meets. I thought you two would be excluded, but… "

Dan Heng simply gapes at him. For the first time in Caelus' life, Dan Heng actually looks shellshocked. He'd be scrabbling to take a photo, if the situation weren't so severe.

Then, Dan Heng sighs. He leans forward, looking suddenly intent.

"Caelus," he says calmly. He presses the back of his hand against Caelus' forehead. The coolness of his touch feels like a soothing balm. "You're delirious. You need a healer—"

"No! Listen," Caelus protests, batting away Dan Heng's hand. "They're—Phainon and Mydei—they're made for each other. And I know you'd never do this, so I thought that maybe

you're just doing this accidentally again—but then you talked about the letters, and I overheard you the other day, and—Dan Heng, this isn't like you!" Caelus draws back. He looks Dan Heng in the eye. "What's going on?"

"... Alright. To clarify, and just so that I know that I'm correct in my thinking," Dan Heng says, sounding strangely like he's speaking through gritted teeth. "You believe… that both Mydei and Phainon are—in love with me. Is that correct?"

"And you like them back," Caelus says miserably, feeling the admission cut through him like a butter knife and he's the poor slab of butter. "Obviously. But you can't just—have one of them and not tell the other, because they're still together!"

Another silence follows. Crickets chirp in the background. The rain continues to fall, occasional droplets splashing onto Caelus' soggy hair.

On his left, Phainon coughs. He opens his mouth, raises his hand like he wants to speak, and then lowers his hand just as hesitantly.

"I can't in good conscience let this happen," Caelus admits, feeling small. "I had to intervene, somehow."

He stares determinedly at the ground. He hopes it swallows him whole.

"You think I have feelings for *Phainon,"* Dan Heng asks him, flatly, ("Hey," Phainon protests weakly in the background) "and *Mydei?"*

"... and probably all the other men that you've picked up?" Caelus says, looking up again. Dan Heng is still staring at him, utterly expressionless. "So I thought it wasn't a foregone conclusion."

Dan Heng continues to stare at him, unblinking. Caelus stares back with the saddest gaze he can muster, until he really can't hold it anymore.

He coughs. "... I feel like I'm missing something."

"Hm," says Dan Heng. He tips his head back to gaze at the sky, looking contemplative. He also looks kind of pained.

"Are my affections really that unknown?" Dan Heng says finally.

"What affections?" Caelus asks, feeling incredibly lost.

Dan Heng doesn't say a word, but his cheeks are steadily growing pinker.

Caelus tries again. "What affections? Dan Heng?"

"Caelus, please," Dan Heng groans. Phainon, having wandered a ways away for some reason, erupts into a suspicious coughing fit.

Caelus sits back, and really thinks about it. If Dan Heng's adamant that his affections aren't for Phainon, and they aren't for Mydei, then who else could they be for? It's not as if there's… anyone else…

He glances at Dan Heng. Dan Heng, who is still holding his gaze, even though his cheeks are flushing a furious red. His hand is still steady on Caelus' shoulder. Caelus thinks about how worried Dan Heng had been just now, and how embarrassed he was in all those moments they were alone together, and…

… ah.

"Oh," Caelus says weakly. "... I may be an idiot?"

At that, Phainon lets out a cheer, and claps gleefully behind them. Like some sort of… giant seal, Caelus thinks deliriously. And Dan Heng… Dan Heng just closes his eyes momentarily, and exhales, before opening them again, looking more determined than ever.

"Do you understand now?" Dan Heng asks him, intently.

Caelus gives him a wobbly smile. His head is *swimming,* but the sour feeling in his gut has evaporated.

Dan Heng has affections for him? This entire time?

Caelus raises his hand, and gives him a wobbly thumbs up. He doesn't get to see Dan Heng's reaction, because black spots start to dance across his vision. *That can't be good,* Caelus thinks, too slowly.

"I'mgoingtopassout," he slurs, before he passes out.

When Caelus wakes up again, he feels infinitely better than he did the last time woke up. Partly because he's waking up in an actual bed with clean sheets, and partly because Dan Heng's holding his hand at his bedside.

"You're great at worrying me," Dan Heng tells him unhappily.

Caelus looks at him. He's still in his rumpled clothes. The sight fills Caelus with fondness. Did Dan Heng stay here the entire time?

“You love me,” Caelus grins. He squeezes Dan Heng’s hand. “That’s so embarrassing for you.”

Before Dan Heng can retort, another voice comes from the door, sounding equally as exasperated.

“Thank Kephale,” Phainon sighs. He’s leaning against the doorframe, looking as sprightly as ever. “I can finally leave.”

Caelus yelps, nearly sending Dan Heng flying. Dan Heng gives him an unimpressed look.

“What are you doing here?” Caelus asks.

“I wanted to make sure you were alright. But also, knowing your track record, I could hardly leave before I heard those words coming from your mouth,” Phainon explains, before he grimaces. “If Mydei and I were anything like you two, then I owe you an apology for what we put you through.”

He looks so sincere that Caelus is half afraid that he’s going to bow to them.

“It’s no big deal,” he hurries. “Thanks for—uh, making sure. Sorry it took so long?”

Phainon only smiles at him. “No apologies needed. But I still haven’t offered my congratulations! I’m glad things worked out for you both.” Then, he grins wider. “May I ask —did we help, at all?”

For a moment, Caelus is confused. Help with what?

“Dan Heng?” Phainon prods, looking like he's barely suppressing a laugh.

“Please remind me to never take both of your advice ever again,” Dan Heng sighs. “Especially after you made it into a competition.”

Slowly, the gears begin to turn in Caelus’ head. When they click, it feels like someone pulled the bed out from under him and sent him crashing to the floor.

He points an accusing finger at Phainon, and then at Dan Heng, and then in the general direction of the sky.

“I thought you three were in a polyamorous relationship,” he shrieks.

“Yes, you told us,” Phainon chuckles, amused.

Caelus feels like his eyes are bugging out of their skull. He whips around to face Dan Heng. “But you—you kept going to Phainon—”

“Truthfully, that misconception was my fault. I was roping him into my schemes,” Phainon admits. “Sorry, Dan Heng.”

Dan Heng nods. “Apology accepted.”

“and Dan Heng, you—” Caelus sputters. How are these two so *calm?!* “You kept getting letters even after Phainon didn’t—”

Dan Heng sighs. “No. I was rereading them. You just happened to catch me in the act.” He looks pointedly at Phainon. “Mydei gives good advice.”

“But—but—” Caelus sputters, again. He thinks back to the reams of letters that Dan Heng kept receiving. None of this adds up, but— “Then how many letters did you get?”

Dan Heng leans back in his chair. “A grand total of two,” he says drily. “Far from the dozens you believed I was receiving. Behind Phainon’s back, even.”

“Hyacine laughed for hours when she heard,” Phainon tells him, eyes twinkling. “I think it really made her day.”

Caelus can’t believe any of this. “But—!”

“I was asking for *advice,*” Dan Heng emphasises. “Homewrecking? Do you really think so little of me? Honestly.”

“You can’t blame me!” Caelus screeches. “I thought you kept sneaking off to write letters, and you were always around Phainon, and Phainon was upset—”

“Don’t worry. That’s been resolved,” Phainon pipes up. “Mydei sends his regards.”

Caelus’ mouth is hanging open. He’s probably gaping like a fish. He feels a little stupid. Scratch that—a lot stupid.

“So it really was—nothing?” he says, dumbfounded. “You didn’t have a crush on either of them, Dan Heng?”

Dan Heng sighs, eternally long-suffering. “No, Caelus, I didn’t.”

“The first time we met, Dan Heng tried to skewer me with Cloud Piercer, because I dared lay a hand on your shoulder,” Phainon laughs. “Considering how perceptive you were to my own feelings, I’m surprised you never realised your own.”

Dan Heng closes his eyes. “Sometimes I fear that his perceptiveness is selective.”

“Hey,” Caelus says weakly.

Phainon claps his hands together. “Well! I’m glad that’s settled,” he says brightly. “I’ll leave you two to catch up.”

He leaves with a wave. Caelus waits for the door to shut behind him, before turning to Dan Heng.

“We’re talking about this,” he demands.

“You brought most of this upon yourself,” Dan Heng reminds him. He reaches out, and brushes the hair from Caelus’ forehead. Caelus won’t deny that the gesture makes his heart flutter a little bit. “But I’m happy to speak about this later. For now, you should rest.”

“Fine. Since my wonderful doctor so kindly insists.” Caelus tries to blow him a kiss, but it’s hard to do so with one free hand and rapidly approaching fatigue.

Dan Heng’s expression softens, and Caelus fights the urge to grin. It’s nice to know he was the one putting those expressions on there, and not their friends. Which—whoops, he’ll have to apologise to both Mydei and Phainon after this.

He does have one last burning question, though. He sits up, looks Dan Heng directly in the eye, and fights to keep his face neutral.

“... Did you really soak all of Okhema?”

Dan Heng’s face quickly switches from fond to exasperated. “I’ll soak *you,”* he threatens.

He squeezes Caelus’ hand anyway, so Caelus counts that as a solid win.

No doomed yaoi for anyone today, he thinks to himself happily. *And hopefully not on the next planet, either…*

Chapter End Notes

"noot why is there a suspicious amount of jing yuan in a fic that doesn’t involve jing yuan” don’t worry about it.

i am @/honeybakedtea on twitter, come say hello!

End Notes

kudos/comments much appreciated, i hope mydei came home to all of you <3

edit 20/03/25: de-anoned and made a couple of minor edits! find me on twt @/honeybakedtea <33

edit 09/12/25: now with some wonderful art by cosumosu - i'm so incredibly honoured ❤️ please show them some love!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!